A CRY OF INNOCENCE

A SENIOR DETECTIVE GRADE FOUR JOSEPH LIND STORY

WITH HIS PARTNER

DETECTIVE TWO ANGELICA "ANGIE" DE LONGO

WRITTEN BY

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A CRY OF INNOCENCE

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This is the 71st story in the series describing the life and career of Senior Detective Joseph Lind and his partners.

Summary:

Perry Matthews is arrested and charged with the murder of Jennifer Crowe, a casual acquaintance of his whom he had hoped would accept his serious overtures. She ignores him and pays with her life. He is sentenced to twelve years in prison with a non-parole period of ten years and three months. Because of his refusal to state to the Parole Board where he has disposed of the body, he must serve out his original sentence.

His cry of innocence is that he did not murder the woman so how is he expected to know where he disposed of her body.

Consequently, Detectives Lind and De Longo are ordered to re-exam the Case and to find the body of Jennifer Crowe. Any Forensic Trace evidence found around the grave site of the woman would confirm the guilt or otherwise of Matthews.

Upon his release Matthews is elated as he walks from the exit gate at the Penitentiary a free man…until Detectives Joseph Lind and his partner Angelica D'Longo greet him, charging him with making false statements to the Parole Board Hearings as per his constant cries of innocence and on suspicion of having committed the homicide murder of Vlad Sumner, another young colleague of Jennifer Crowe.

His cry of innocence again falling on deaf ears!

A CRY OF INNOCENCE

SENIOR HOMICIDE DETECTIVE JOSEPH LIND
with
DETECTIVE ANGELICA 'ANGIE' DE LONGO

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CHAPTER ONE

That he was Jewish surprised me. He had never shown any religious leanings that I knew of for the period that I had been his Acting Boss. With a name like Darryn Fielders you would never suspect it…I guess he could have changed his name years ago to allay any conflict against him. In his condition, there was always a chance that he would feel defenceless…helpless in the face of an enemy. An intruder. All my subordinates displayed some form of insecurity due to their handicaps which you can't blame them for…

He had wheeled into my Office in a bundle of nerves. I knew at once something was up…that is why I am a good boss according to most who have ever worked with me…my sixth sense!

"You know those attacks in the Eastern Suburbs last week? Anti-Jewish sentiment that they now say will cost over three hundred thousand dollars to repair? One of those vehicles that was damaged was ours…just spray-painted garbage on the sides and windscreen…hah! They can't even spell Isreal correctly…notice that!? We are going to get rid of it when we get it back from the Repairers…it was my wife's vehicle; we had it specially fitted out to accept my wheelchair when we purchased it new. It is just a bloody inconvenience is all as I can manhandle myself in and out of our sedan car…and if fitted with the correct gear, I could drive it myself."

He slowed to a stop. He had run out of wind.

"So, what's the problem?" I succinctly asked. I was busy writing my first novel, 'The Perfect Profession' and to be interrupted wrecked my chain of thought…it could never be retrieved. I was a little miffed at the interruption. I know to do such a thing during working hours was sacrosanct to immediate dismissal but this Branch…my subordinates ran themselves. They did not need me peering over their shoulders because I had little to nothing to do…so to fill in the daylight hours I began to write that 'Great Australian Novel' that had frustrated me for many years.

"Arrh…the wife and I are considering moving to the In-laws until this whole shebang blows over…all this antisemitic shit."

"A little over the top, don't you think?" I remarked a little too quickly. "There is no indication that the perps of this anti-Jewish bullshit have any intention of attacking persons. I believe it will only be days before someone is arrested and charged with the crime. A 'Task Force' has

been established to snare the culprits. It won't take them long to get on top of the stupidity…we don't need this in Australia."

"It's just…"

"You feel insecure…" I interjected. "Because you are confined to a wheelchair and can't fight back like in the old days when you were on the front line being an incredible copper before the accident confined you to that wheelchair. Your intellect showed you were a shoo-in for a position here instead of sitting around a Convalescent Hospital but as I said, your current confinement leaves you a little insecure and frightened…that about right?" I looked across at him with that look of concern. I knew that I had nailed it in one.

"Yeah…I guess." He nodded slowly. Looking down at his hands that he was wringing together. His knuckles white with the exertion. "All it will take is for some hot-blooded young Jew boy to react to all this shit to ignite the whole thing into a bloody war here on the suburban streets of Sydney with people like me unable to do shit…"

"Can't see it Darryn. Mate. Not here in Australia. Those looking to display their opposition to Jews…to Palestinians…to Muslims seem to run out of puff quickly when the coppers come a'knocking. Don't do anything drastic for a couple of days…you know, like moving house for a couple of weeks…as the local cops are on top of it!"

Two weeks later Darryn applied for four weeks off. His anxiety levels and insecurities having overtaken commonsense. His two adult kids and three dogs remained in the family home while Darryn and his wife spent the time up Forster-way away from the things that scared him. Under the watchful eye of his parents and in-laws.

Two weeks in, his house was subject to an arson attack. Thankfully, flames did not take hold, and the result was a charred front wall. Nothing else. That was too much for Darryn who offered his resignation, sold the eastern suburbs family home to invest in a lakeside bungalow up Forster-way close to his parents and in-laws. They settled in and soon had a roaring business in a Coffee Café with views. Popular with both locals and the 'Grey Brigade' and 'Grey Nomads.'

> *As a footnote, the coppers of a special squad set up to arrest all anti-Jewish 'painters' and arsonists made an outstanding arrest. The Number One Comanchero boss was arrested for 'creating public mischief' with the police stating he was hiring young hot head Muslim youths to carry out these antisemitic crimes…to create public mischief! His arrest has curbed the rubbish to almost zilch!*

Go figure…

Why go to all that trouble unless you have a twisted mind or a sick sense of humour…or both!

CHAPTER TWO

I walked up to the vacant Darryn Fields' desk now occupied by Senior Sergeant 'Dolly' Parsons who was left partially paralysed from the waist down in a traffic accident. She was pursuing a drug-fuelled idiot who escaped the pursuit but was arrested two days later on a charge of drug possession, cash valued at close to one hundred thousand dollars and illegal fire-arms found in his vehicle.

However, Parsons' prognosis was promising. Her outlook on life positive. Her disposition cheerful which made her popular with her colleagues…and she had a beautiful smile.

I tapped her on the shoulder.

"Two bodies left on the steps of the Mosque out Auburn way. CCTV coverage shows six persons carrying the lifeless bodies to the front steps at around oh-two-thirty hours this morning. The two deceased have yet to be identified. Let's keep a head of the pack and see whether we have any information in our memory banks relating to young Jewish lads capable of doing this…and any alternative gangs who have it in for Muslims…your task for the day."

I left her alone to cocoon myself in my Office to write another chapter in my novel. It wasn't until the following morning while were all congregated in the Lunchroom come Conference Room that she spoke up.

"Those two deceased? Identified early yesterday…but the names suppressed and will not be released as it is a rather embarrassing point for the Federal Government. Two Palestinians Hamas fighters…or more accurately two Hamas Lieutenants returned to Australia for recreational leave away from the front fighting the Jewish State…you can see how the release of their identity and their career paths could be detrimental to the Australian Government and their policies of tight border controls. Amir Mohamoud and Farrad del Farah. Both thirty-four years of age with red flags on their movements. Knowing their identities has increased the number of possible perps who would do them in…including the AFP and ASIO who also had their reasons I would suggest but are not known for black ops…that is killing people." She nodded her head and smiled, pleased with her examination and result.

“Anyone else of significance?” I asked sardonically. I wasn’t thrilled with the accusations flying around as most were based on half-truths, straight out lies or vivid imaginations…but that was a part of the job. That, and reading between the lines.

“Apart from Mossad you mean…and the CIA?” She responded. That smile again.

“Hah! Bloody jeezuz! Alright. Prepare a Report for my signature to pass onto the investigating Murder Dees. I think the Murder Squad will lose the investigation if any one of those organisations are involved. Arrh…who are the investigating Dees involved? The Murder Squad has taken possession of the Case in the first instance, hasn’t it?” I asked as I walked to her position at the large table that was our coffee/lunch break table. It was a strict rule here that there be no eating or drinking over their computers or keyboards…dripped coffee and crumbs were common around here which was no fault of theirs, just a by-product of their conditions.

If the Murder Squad had received the investigation in the first instance, they were about to lose it was my estimation as other ‘alphabet soup’ organisations were swimming around the bait.

“Um…I don’t know, and I disagree with you, Boss. If any one of those overseas intelligence organisations were involved, they wouldn’t just dump the bodies on the front steps of a Sydney suburban Mosque…they would have made the bodies just disappeared. No, I reckon it is a homegrown group who don’t have the resources to make the bodies just vanish…it’s a hard job making two bods disappear…and I reckon there is a message in the delivery. *‘Keep your hands clean and away from Australia.’* That’s an educated guess on my part, boss.”

I nodded giving her theory consideration as it made sense.

“Mmm…yeah…I’ll go along with that. Have you got anything of substance on the body dump?”

“Several homegrown groups who could…could be involved. The first is a slight chance of being involved. I’ll only mention them as they came up on the second trawl through our logarithm memory banks. ‘Sons of Abrahim’ came out of the woodwork after the Oct ’23 debacle. They keep the fires burning by delivering letterbox pamphlets on the wisdom of the IDF military assaults on Hamas in Palestine and the Hezbollah in Lebanon…”

“Bullies who are living on the world’s sympathies for the Holocaust victims of World War Two…” One of the group seated around me interrupted. “Jews have been riding on that catastrophe since the war…they’re nothing but bullies wanting all Palestinians out of Gaza…and the West Bank…where to? Anyone’s guess and the Zionists do not care where they go. As long as they are out of those two regions the Jews will be satisfied having basically dissolved the state of Palestine. I suspect that most of the Palestinian refugees would head for

Egypt who has said they do not want any more refugees from Palestine. They've got more than their share now, finding it hard to house and feed them on any given day!"

"Bullshit! Israel was looking for any excuse to bomb the bejeezus out of the Hamas regime…mainly in the Gaza strip and that cowardly attack by Hamas last year gave them the excuse they were looking for."

"You saying they permitted…were aware of what Hamas soldiers were going to do back in October when all this started!? That's utter bullshit!"

"It gave the Israelis justification to bomb the bejezuz out of the Gaza Strip acquiesced by many of the world's governments…more so for the U.S. to up their supply of further weapons…the U.S. is laughing all the way to the bank what with this Middle East business and the Russian/Ukrainian War as well."

"That's a ridiculous accusation…" Another of my Officers responded.

"Okay guys…calm down. This is just a talkfest not a précis on a person's political leanings." I interrupted, surprised that it had escalated so quickly.

"Yeah, well…whatever. 'The Sons of Abrahim' are a long shot for the damage done last week in Wahroonga. The Palestinian Brotherhood labelled as a terrorist unit and are illegal in Australia. They have emerged and receded as conflicts in the Middle East flare up and subside. However, they are an organization that has gained confidence as the challenges in the region persist. They…or their sympathisers here in Sydney would be capable of conducting those acts in Wahroonga last week…but they've shown little forethought in the way they have caused damage…mainly damage to government buildings up until now….and they have never killed anyone on home soil…"

"A lone wolf or two…" Someone suggested.

"More than likely the obvious scenario with those responsible having ties with the 'Brotherhood' or with an Imam who wants to cause as much mischief as possible. But the question of who may have killed those two Muslim men and dumped their bodies on the Mosque front steps is not in our logarithms…we do not have a straight answer or facts to pass onto the Investigating Officers in the Murder Squad…and who removed those same bodies some hours later is anyone's guess. What is factual is that we'll never see those bodies again. They would have been dumped in the middle of the Pacific Ocean within hours of being removed from the Mosque steps."

"From the whispers I've heard, they will soon lose the Case to the AFP which means we'll be out of the picture also. Mossad will be hanging onto the shirttails of all those AFP Detectives

who have been allocated the Case…along with the FBI I reckon…you can bet your house on it!"

"Remember fellas, that doesn't mean we cannot continue to delve into the situation…you never know…" I suggested wanting to keep the cheerful outlook on a high as too often once a Case is handed over to the AFP, we gained little kudos for work done…whether it was the Murder Squad or the GRCUnit they are loathe to credit us with certain information.

That information I had gained from Neville as I sat with him for the week prior to his forthcoming operation…which was again postponed for the third time…medical reasons and lack of support staff necessary for that type of critical and intricate surgery. That lengthened my tenure here as Head Choko which I didn't mind. It was less exerting than being a Murder Dee juggling several Cases above your head.

Thus, my tenure as the acting head of the Police Intelligence Unit again extended much to the delight of my lovely wife who preferred me home for dinner on a regular basis when she and my two daughters sat at the table with me. Something that was often lacking when I had a full load of murder cases that I was juggling trying to keep my chin above water. My mind elsewhere thinking suspiciously and listing possible Persons of Interest instead of being on my lovely wife and three daughters.

CHAPTER THREE

"Joseph Lind? If you keep staring at me like you are doing, I will refuse to continue…"

"I want to make sure you do it right…"

"I know what I am doing. I would not have agreed to proofread what you have written so far if I didn't know what I was doing. Go play in the traffic …or paint the outside of the house!"

"Okay…okay. I get it…but the traffic is light, and it is raining…how about I make you a cup of coffee?"

"A good idea…and a piece of toast to get you out of my hair."

I stood to be a good boy but immediately noticed red squiggly lines, words crossed out and other words added. The page I could see on the computer screen was a mass of red marks. My ego was dented severely! And how she had transposed those red marks, squiggly lines and

new words onto the computer screen image was beyond me…and I truly did not want to know!

"Whaaa…" I began, to be silenced by my wife's growl.

"Coffee! Toast! Two slices!"

As I quietly came back into Danni's bedroom come Computer Room carrying a plate of toast and her steaming coffee mug she was shaking her head. Over her shoulder she offered her thanks then spinning the desk chair towards me she glared at me. She broke eye contact as she took a large bite of toast, purring like a satisfied cat.

"I thought you were the 'gun' Report Writer on the Squad Floor…Arrh…ta. Thanks." She sipped on her first taste of coffee for the morning. Another bite of toast lathered with butter and vegemite melted together as she liked it as she looked up at me.

"This casts me back to my school days when I would have a similar effect on my composition…Grade three or four…our teacher back then was brutal saying we should all be able to write correct English compositions at that level. They weren't called Essays until we reached 'big' school…high school back then."

"You don't like it, huh?"

"No…Joe. I like your overall style and the telling of the story it's just…the construction…the correct English is letting you down…no, keep doing it and I will keep correcting it as I am enjoying it. You'll learn by your mistakes. One thing Joe. Is this meant to be a work of fiction or an autobiographical novel because if it is the latter, then you have put yourself and your mate in the poo. You describe how you kill and bury the two managers of a cannabis farm out west of Ballina…two Comanchero members…that could get you a nasty payback from the boys…admittedly forty-odd years later…or it could see you die in prison for the two crimes. There's no 'statute of limitation on murder charges,' in Australia, is there? I guess there will be a couple more before we have concluded the story, eh? That worries me. Another thing, if you intend to only cover the period that you and your mate were undercover plying the north coast, you should approach your former mate to obtain his approval…and his blessing on the story and his involvement and inclusion. You'll need his approval on the project before you go much further."

"Mmm…I never thought of that. It's been a long time since I spoke to him last and I doubt he'll be positive about my advance."

"Joe? Time has a way of healing…you've got to get his written endorsement on the story before you go much further."

CHAPTER FOUR

My head was spinning with the laws of grammar and why you shouldn't or should express a sentence. Double negatives I still don't understand…and tenses!? Past, present and future… Forget the 'ands' to stretch out a sentence as short sentences make it easier for the reader to read…and much more. I wondered what my various bosses over the years had really thought about my Reports. If I was considered the best on the floor, how bad were the others!?

I sat heavily in the desk chair noticing I was the only one on the floor. Glancing at the clock it was way too early even for the habitual early starters. For reasons I can't fathom, those early morning 'before start time' exercises in the sub-basement gym had slipped from their regular habit…I figured I was getting too old for such nonsense, but my biorhythm clock still held firm to the practise of early morning rises to arrive at work well before other gym junkies.

I logged on as I made myself my first morning coffee. Another homicide…three in fact overnight. The boys will be busy if the nightshift guys let the three Cases slip to the dayshift guys…bet you they will as they are under-resourced and overworked…always.

A middle-aged woman kidnapped from her home, bundled into a late model Audi Quatro found but streets over burnt to ashes…the woman's body still inside. Her eight-year-old son bashed to an inch of his life in hospital in a critical condition…that sounded like an interesting Case. Who would want to bash an eight year old boy to an inch of his life…someone who was known to the boy and could be identified by the lad.

The other two were domestic violence Cases that went the full nine yards…kids involved. That turned me off!

I returned to my desk and took a deep breath. I was nervous. It had been over fifteen years since we last spoke and that didn't leave a friendly aftertaste back then. I was from the 'firm' that believed in nurturing contacts as they could always be useful in the future…you never knew. He was now heading for a Deputy Commissioner's position where I guess contacts at that level had more to do with politics not information nor help.

I cleared my throat and dialled in the general Police Force number asking pleasantly to be patched through to the Chief Detective Inspector-in-charge, Southern Area of NSW. He would have been in that job for at least fifteen years…could have been longer I mused as a pleasant voice informed me that the Chief Inspector was not available for the day. He was in Melbourne for a joint State Conference…bread and butter at his level.

“Could I leave a number for him, Detective? He will return your call some time tomorrow.” She offered melodically. “Is it a business call or is it a personal matter…I don’t recognise your name, Detective.”

I left the necessary details and dialled out…expecting not to hear from him ever…I twisted around and bought up my ‘Great Australian Novel’ that I was now referring to as the ‘Great Australian Exposé into the NSW Police Force Training Practises.’ A long title that I was not thrilled with…’The Perfect Profession’ seemed so much more…professional…and correct.

I was down to the last Chapter or two rounding out the novel to two hundred and sixty pages. Tellie advised me she would cut this by ten or so pages. She was enjoying herself which was unexpected. I had re-read several of her proofreading exercises and found the words easier to read with my sense of humour evident in every chapter…that or my tongue-in-cheek progress noticeable throughout. I had been worried about the number of women both Baz and I had bedded in the back of that Panel Van or lying on the grass beside it on some windswept headland with the sound of the waves tumbling, roaring on the rocks below…a reminder of a scene out of ‘From Here to Eternity.’ She did not bat an eyelid saying that such things happened when two virile young studs were centre stage and envied for that talent in cutting up a wave…with free alcohol and nifty tunes afterwards!

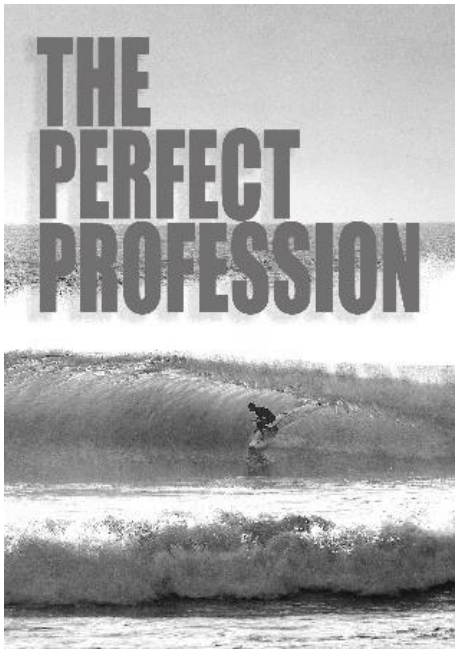
The last paragraph was where we walked unsteadily down a dirt track away from the Malabar Sand Hills. Baz had his arm around my waist. He was crying…sobbing his heart out.

‘Sorry mate…’ he blurted between sobs. *‘This is the end. I’m opting out of this partnership and being an undercover cop…I can’t take any more.’* He had just finished digging his own grave and by a stroke of luck managed to turn the tables on the man standing above him with a pistol in his hand. He told me he almost decapitated the man as he was readying to fire the gun. The bloke almost fell on top of him. He jumped out of the trench and covered it over. The copper’s name was Detective Three ‘Rusty’ Shields… Gus Batelli’s loyal Number Two.

I would connect the dots in years to come as he was the father of Shelley Shields who fifteen years later became my partner for over five years…funny how things work out as if written by an imaginative author who could predict the future.

I thought that a subtle way to finish the piece…

I heard the happy sounds of my team as they wheeled, strutted, and limped their way onto the floor…bang on nine. A new day had just commenced…a day of camaraderie and good cheer which always lifted my ‘feel’ for the day.



CHAPTER FIVE

It was two days later, and I still had not heard from my former undercover partner. The crew had all disappeared bang on five to permit the specialised buses to get all the PI Officers home in good time. I was still not used to this punctual situation occurring. Bang on nine they all wandered onto the floor together and come five, they were all out the door! Together! A cheerful good-bye for the day and the hope of seeing each other on the morrow…

I realised normal modes of travel to work were out of the question for all of them. Those specialised buses their support to feel almost normal. If that had not been available…three buses with one held in storage in case of a mechanical breakdown or another incident occurring. All were serviced and kept under the Force's Transport control. It was reassuring to learn that the buses were specially built and purchased because of the generous support of all Police Force charities and hospital staff generosity over eighteen months while this whole set-up was being thought of. The Government provided nothing except the idea for the Branch to function with these people generously rewarded with wages commiserate with other similar scales of salary in the Force. The attitude by certain wise ones was that their bodies may have been broken but in certain cases their brains were still highly motivated and useful to the Force.

I guess I could understand the attitude of all persons on the floor…they were lucky to so be employed…

It was after six when I closed my laptop and stood to go home. The area lifeless now all my charges had departed for the day. My phone rang. I was disinclined to answer it. I eventually conceded as I stood in the Lift Lobby waiting for that ride down.

"Police Intelligence. Detective Lind. To whom am I speaking?" I answered tiredly.

"Chief Superintendent Detective Barry Holtz. You rang me…"

No how are you; how's your missus? And kids? The job. Nothing like that at all!

He was intent on displaying the gap between our Grades…some sort of snotty-nosed highflyer who liked to ensure his position was appreciated. I wondered whether I was supposed to bow before him even though I had now been joined by several other persons waiting for that ride

down to ground or into the Basement area where my unmarked ride was always garaged. A condition for my acceptance as the Branch Head, albeit for a short period only.

I went to ask how he was; how the girls were; they'd be all grown up now I suppose…and Cyn…how was my woman who I should have married a long time ago instead of introducing her to my best mate Bazza. You know, light banter to crack the ice…

"You rang me Detective. What is it you wish to speak to me about?" He repeated coldly and robotically.

Mmm…like that, eh? I hurried back into the Police Intelligence Office area where all the computers continued to work without the oversighting of a human being. Nobody to overhear the conversation.

"Um…I'm writing a book on my…*our* early life in the NSW Police Force. Calling it the 'Perfect Profession' as that is what it was for those first couple of years. Chasing the waves, the girls and the distributors of cannabis leaf being transported into the greater Sydney area. You know…from when we first met at the Enlistment Office in Phillip Street in the city…right through our Academy days to those few short years where surfing the breaks was supreme…"

There was silence for some moments. I was on the verge of asking had we been cut off when I heard a low growl.

"Harrumph!" He broke the silence. "If my name is stated, inferred, intimated, or connected to those times in any way where illegal acts may have been stated, inferred, or intimated I will sue the pants off you. If you were hoping to obtain my agreement to include me in this little piece of fantasy that you are writing you are mistaken. Under no circumstance is my name to be mentioned or even connected to yours…do you understand me. I do not intend to use up my retirement age in prison…do you understand me. You will receive a letter of total disagreement from my Solicitors in the coming days!"

Plonk…he hung up!

Bugger me!

And we were good mates once upon a time…extra close where we knew we would back each other up in every tight circumstance…we were excellent as a team…the best so it was whispered.

I sat there for some time wondering what I should do next. The initial Draft completed, and on its second proofread and edit. Without Bazza Holtz's involvement it falls flat…extremely flat and then his parting words hit me. I had been so wound up in the story, in the re-living a

period of my life that was next to perfection as far as I was concerned not thinking of the consequences when all the dirty linen was aired…I could go to prison and I wondered for the first time who had been looking over the two of us and who had washed us clean of every one of those illegal acts…like about seven homicides...and a heap of other illegal activities that were accountable in a Court of Law…who!!??

I racked my brains trying to think who had been our saviour…our invisible protector for those several years where we were skidding extremely close to illegal matters…and sometimes stepping over it!!

I didn't like having such a quandary hanging over my head…who-ever would be long gone I comforted myself as I headed back out into the Lift Lobby…long gone but you can bet the house it is written down and described in detail in some bland file buried deep in the archival shelves…I hoped.

This was not doing my anxiety levels much good…another night where little sleep was the order of the night!

CHAPTER SIX

I pushed my coffee mug away from me as I agreed with Tellie in her initial opinion of my writing skills.

We were huddled together in our computer room looking intently at the large computer screen that was connected somehow to both our laptops.

"You were right, my love. This is not the way to go. Writing an autobiographical account of my life in the Force from the time of enlistment until my undercover partner called it quits would be opening a bloody large can of worms. I wasn't thinking…the words on the paper would have ensured he and I would spend the rest of our lives in prison…why didn't I see it?"

"You were too busy getting the words down to have time to comprehend what you were writing. He was that rude, huh? What a crud…you guys were as thick as thieves once a bloody time…you even took me down to their joint at Batemans Bay to meet them…several times…remember? They were a lovely family. I bet you they're divorced now…a bloody shame to see it go down the gurgler…what now?"

I shrugged, ran my fingers through my fast disappearing hairline, pulled at my earlobe, and shook my head slowly. I still had that urge…that want to put in writing what I had experienced for all my adult life. People would enjoy the read, I felt sure…them divorced? That would be sad but only from the point of Cynthia and the kids. Barry Holtz did not fit into my meandering thoughts at all. I wondered whether other people have this type of falling out where the threads of friendship untwirl quickly without an effort to resolve the split…what really went wrong between Baz and me? Even now, I'm not too sure…too many elements that could cause problems if one wanted to dig into our history…maybe…I'm not too sure but one thing I do know is that there has never been a deeper friendship for me since…makes you wonder, eh?

In fact, the older I have got, the more aloof I have become. Mingling only with what family I knew I had and keeping in touch regular-like with all my previous partners…except Sophie Grasso, the Motor Engineer and driver…why? I had no idea. I promised myself there and then I would right that wrong soon…

CHAPTER SEVEN

This early morning arrival at work long before I was due in at oh-eight-hundred and thirty hours was starting to grate on me. Once upon a time I would bounce down to the sub-basement gym where the heated pool invited me to do lengths of the pool without stopping. A quick hot and cold shower, a round with the rowing machine, the running machine then a masochistic rub-down by an over-enthusiastic massage therapist would leave me longing for a rest behind my desk on the Murder Squad floor.

That was now history with not a bone in my body missing the daily ritual…of some years ago!

Angie De Longo my young partner however enthusiastically embraced the morning ritual and was known when work regime permitted, to back it up in the late afternoon before heading for home. Sharing the gym with the 'early' starters from the Night Squad.

She came in smelling of a mixture of chlorine and artificial sweet-smelling perfumes…all smiles and in love with the world…

Well, not to-day. She was sad…depressed…more than I've ever seen her before. I knew something terrible was up.

"Sophie Grasso? She had a prang on the weekend. A normal weekend 'meet' with 'uphill races' and the normal circuit racing. She had a bad one during one of those circuit races.

Rolled her much loved MGB Pursuit hotted-up car…all her own work. Um…she's in Westmead under sedation…crumpled her most cherished possession and herself…"

I sat there wondering how life works. It was only yesterday when I realised Sophie was the only former partner I had not kept in touch with…and how I should remedy this mistake…funny, huh?

"She's under a surgical coma…is that right?" I asked now in a shocked situation unable to think straight. "What hospital?"

"Westmead General…in ICU under sedation not an induced coma." Angie replied softly. She could see the change in me.

"I should go and see her…" I suggested awkwardly finding it difficult to stand.

"Joe? A waste of time as she won't know you're there…" Was the reply.

"But I will!" I countered angrily as I again attempted to stand. Succeeding, I unsteadily made it to the Boss's door. She looked up at the light tap I gave her door. I went to speak but instead began to cry. Ronnie Faye quickly stood from her chair to guide me to a visitor's chair opposite her own. She looked at Angie who had followed me in, getting a reasonable description of the terrible event. Angie too was close to tears.

The Boss knew more than I. Angie and Sophie were good friends…so to speak. Angie living at Sophie's place at Abbotsford, catching the ferry each morning to the Parramatta Ferry jetty as Sophie had done before her. They had known one another since the Academy days though Angie as an adult student was several years ahead of Sophs…

All this was news to me including that they were sharing the large house that Sophie had extended to a two-storey place some years previously. She'd had problems with Boarders for some time but that appeared to be resolved…

"Ange? Go with Joe to the hospital…and make sure he gets home in one piece. You have my approval to drive the Unmarked without Joe's presence once you drop him home…okay?" She commanded.

We made the hospital in good time without siren, lights or honking horn. We parked in the position for 'Police Business Only,' getting a rundown of Sophie's present condition from the ICU Sister which had not changed from that when she was admitted.

I sat on one side of the bed like a stone effigy while Angie sat on the other side fidgeting, standing to look out the window, walking out of the ward to return an hour later with two hot

coffees to go. She placed one in front of me on a bedside table…it went cold. An extremely rare event!

"Joe? I'm not as patient as you…I'm going back to work…"

It was then that I thought the two were not an 'item' but just living under the same roof.

"Go home, Ange. Tellie is going to pick me up on the way through after she knocks off for the day…not far out of her way and I'm sure she'd like to see Sophs as they clicked …yeah…go home."

Angie glanced at the large ward clock…it had just gone oh-fourteen-hundred hours! She abruptly stood to walk from the ward. I would see her at work tomorrow probably.

Left by myself I wondered why I was so adamant in staying, sitting by a bed whose patient didn't know I was there. Was it guilty conscience?

I thought that was close to the mark…

CHAPTER EIGHT

I can imagine the rumourmongers whispering away as I walked the length of the Homicide Squad floor to my desk towards the rear of the room. I didn't care as my heart was singing 'good to be back.' One or two of my colleagues stood to shake my hand, ruffle what little hair I had left or to just congratulate me on my return…the prodigal son returns once again.

It's not that I didn't enjoy my stint as Head of Police Intelligence…no, I more than enjoyed it and the pleasant camaraderie with the dozen Officers who represented the Branch. A successful thinking outside the box that kept these intelligent and enthusiastic people gainfully employed instead of chained to some type of special bed or seated in front of a TV set for most of the day. Relying on a stranger for the base things of life…or a tired wife or family member to carry out those chores.

It's just that…well…in my situation, I was one step back from the coal face. Yes, it was extremely satisfying to know that on more than one occasion the information dealt out by the Branch led to a satisfactory conclusion to several homicide cases, a DV case or two, a series of robberies in three different regions of the State and permitting an honest cop to escape a wrongful arrest for bribery…very satisfying but it was the homicide cases that I missed. The

hunt. The thrust and parry of identifying the guilty person…or persons…and the best part of all…the arrest and charge as they stood, head bowed before me!

The stint in PI too short a period in some ways but just long enough to allow me to re-charge the tired and rundown batteries.

"Detective?" The Boss yelled after me as I passed his Office. "After you've settled, come and see me will you…with Angie. The two of you are back together."

I smiled at Angie as I came to her desk. Me having shaken hands with most of my colleagues on my way across the floor. Angie stood quickly to hug me which surprised me though I did return the hug…which surprised me even more!

"Welcome home Joe. Good to see you back…Sophie is showing signs of coming out of her stupor…if that is the right word. Later this week we should call in to see her, eh?"

"You saw me three days ago. Last Friday. You were making sure I was starting this Monday back at my normal desk…and you drove me to the hospital and stayed with me for about an hour last Monday…"

"Mmm…and it is the first time I've ever seen you let your coffee go cold." A wide smile said it all…

I settled into my desk sure that Angie had tidied up the mess that would have accumulated on my desktop. Whenever someone vacates their desk for any period, their desk becomes a repository for all the junk that circulates around the Office. Memorandums, must see Branch memos, whose retirement 'drinkies' nights I have missed and essential information to someone that is forgotten the moment it is circulated…and then there is the current files that sit more comfortably on my desk then on the owners' desks!

"Come on partner, let's see what the Boss has in store for us…must be something big if he is going to corral both of us first thing this morning."

"The Perry Matthews Homicide Case of some twelve…fifteen years ago…" Angie offered.

The name rang a bell but as it had not been my Case back then, there was little knowledge of its detail.

"Arrh…we now have a person…a Mister Murray Bridge who has come forward to confess to the murder of Jennifer Crowe some thirteen…fourteen years ago. Perry Matthews has served eleven of his twelve-year sentence for the death of the woman…"

“No parole?”

“Arrh…I’ll let the boss fill you in on the details…” Angie said over her shoulder as she led me to the Boss’s door. Knocked twice then walked in as the boss beckoned us into his ample Office a lot larger than the one in the PI Branch…at least twice as big.

“Close the door.” The boss ordered without looking up at our entry.

After we had settled into the visitors’ chairs opposite him, he began cheerfully to ask after certain fellows in PI and what I thought of them and the future of the PI Branch. As I spoke of the six months I had spent as Head of the Branch, I unknowingly had a smile on my face. I relaxed into the visitor chair opposite the Boss to relive certain aspects of the job that had impressed me.

“You didn’t apply for the position…you were held in high regard by the guys up there…” He offered as he looked intently at me.

I felt he had full knowledge of my stint as Branch Head.

“As I told them all on my last day there, even though those few weeks…well several months were more than delightful, I missed the cut and thrust of the chase…the homicide cases where I could see that I was making a difference by catching the bastards…almost always with the PI Branch’s help. They all seemed to understand as I reckon most would have loved to be here themselves.”

The Boss nodded as though he understood.

“Okay…first up…how’s Sophie Grasso? Good? Arrh, good news for a change. Your first Case back here at the coal face…okay? Do you remember the Perry Matthews Case?”

I nodded. Swayed my hand side to side to indicate detail was thin.

“Only vaguely though. It wasn’t my Case back then…he killed his lover because she wanted to end the relationship…nothing brutal but he stuffed her panties into her mouth…she choked to death according to the Prosecution at the time of the Trial. Her body never found so I’ve always wondered how the fact that she choked to death was established…with her own panties…his sentence based thinly on circumstantial evidence and forensic trace material…no witnesses to the crime.”

“Yep…that’s the one. He has another year and a bit to run on his sentence of twelve years and six months. He has another chance at parole before that date but that will not happen as he refuses to inform the Parole Board of where he hid the body…or at least buried it! His defence

has always been that as he didn't kill her, he has no idea where her body is buried…" He nodded towards three File Carriers. "There's the full history of the man from the time the victim's husband reported her missing up until Matthews' last Parole Board Hearing…it's all yours. Your main examination is to find the poor woman's body…it's been a mystery now for umpteen years so I have doubts that you will succeed in your quest…sorry, that's the wrong attitude…um…we need to locate the woman's body to round out any hope of Matthews filing for a mistrial and wrongful arrest…and sue the pants off the NSW Police Force for wrongful imprisonment for a dozen years."

There was silence for some time as we mulled over our new assignment…a re-examination of a Case that had been solved and attested. I was looking for something more…

The Boss broke the silence.

"Arrh, Ang…would you mind leaving Joe and I alone?" He nodded towards the office door as his order for her to leave us.

Angie left the office quietly closing the door. The Boss looked down at his clenched hands somewhat embarrassed by what he had to disclose to me…

CHAPTER NINE

"Joe? I guess you will learn soon enough through the rumour mill, which is rife through the corridors of this building as you know, but I wanted to advise you in person. I was informed this morning that I have won my three Appeals Cases…I will be the new DI in Police Intelligence. I rang my wife straight away. She was over the moon. Three and a half years before retirement and truly, I did not want to carry on here for that period. This position is one of the most important in the Force…and one of the most demanding. You are never too sure what time you will knock off and who will want your presence immediately no matter what time of the day or night it is. My wife was over the moon. There's no change in the Grade but there's a huge difference in when you'll get home…you know all this as you have just spent almost six months in the position." A nod. A smile to back up his words.

I nodded and stood to lean across his desk to shake his hand and wish him well. It was a wise move on his behalf as he was finding it harder to resist the pressure of the job…and it was starting to show in his demeanour, lack of humour and short fuse.

"Anything you can tell me about the Branch? Who the agitators are and who are the reliable personnel." He asked as he again leaned back in his chair to clench his hands together on his

ever-expanding waistline.

"They're a good mob," I commenced. "All of them wanting to come to work, wanting to make a difference and wanting to back each other up. You must understand they all went through the ranks that we have all been through. The savage physical exertions expected of you during the Academy days. Being able to defend yourself in any scramble …now…because of their physical limitations, they are all to some degree defenceless…and knowing it. Little things can set them off…like…he was one of the best performers of the group. A quick and alert mind but tied to a wheelchair. Darryn Fielders. He was Jewish which I didn't know. Lived in the eastern suburbs right in the middle of all that anti-Semitic bullshit that flared up last year. He was so worried that he resigned and moved near his parents and in-laws up Forster way. Up the coast. That's how…arrh…how fragile he really felt. I tried to explain it was a storm in a teacup and when the major players were arrested, the whole thing would die down…as it has. He could not be relieved of his concerns... I regretted his departure. What I'm saying is that you need to be on top of their fears and fragilities and special needs. They are a brilliant bunch who will ensure you can commence work at a specific time and be home for tea at the same time every night…arrh, who is going to warm this seat until it is advertised?"

"I reckon you already have a fair idea. Veronica 'Ronnie' Faye from Major Robbery and White-collar Crime. She'll slot in wonderfully well. An open, optimistic, and fair-minded operator…arrh…you are still not interested in the job?"

"Nah…never…" He already knew of my opinion, but the hierarchy would always be asking the same question hoping I may change my mind.

"Mmm…they'll have her acting in the role until she gets enough experience to beat any appellant who wants to take her on…good luck with that!" The Boss added.

"Mmm…" I squeezed the tip of my nose then tugged at my earlobe…a nervous reaction becoming more noticeable.

I remained in his office for some time jawing over the politics of the Service and how obvious it can be and how divergent it could be. Talking about Police Intelligence and the good guys who will always ensure its existence.

Life goes on…and another female boss of the Murder Squad will sit comfortably in the chair.

I rose ready to leave the Office when the door opened and 'Ronnie' Faye walked in, all smiles and camaraderie.

"Arrh, Joe. I was hoping I'd catch you." She held out her hand to take mine in a firm shake. I thought the meeting staged…cynical me!

“Congrats on your move …” The woman directed her comments at the Boss. “There was a lot of politics involved in your selection, so I believe.”

I felt I should leave. This conversation way above my base pay grade and three grades above my present level. I eased myself towards the now open door without either person breaking their conversation gambits…I just wasn’t there anymore according to them! They had just forgotten to dismiss me…

CHAPTER TEN

I'd just completed a double shift with a twelve-hour surveillance operation tacked onto the back. Volunteering not an option!

The two worst professions for doing this type of thing when they should have been the last to conduct this insane practise were the Cops and the Medical fraternity. Young eager Medical Students straight after completion of last term exams thrust into enforced 72-hour continuous shifts with sleeping on the job permitted. Catnaps between car accident victims being ambulanced in.

An absurd situation when life and death decisions and a clearness of mind are of paramount import.

Immediate reaction times.

Clear and concise actions.

The right decisions made, not blurred by lack of sleep for over 72 hours!

Fortunately, my young partner for the elongated surveillance shift was an enthusiastic young Probational Constable not that long out of the Academy and wanting desperately to strip off the uniform and wear mufti as a plain-clothes Detective in the Murder Squad as first choice. Very few achieved this goal, but it was not for the want of trying by so many. My young partner agreed to let me sleep two five-hour shifts on the back seat of the unmarked hoping that this larger than life, legendary figure of many a homicide, an undercover Vice Officer and Narcotics Officer extraordinaire, would somehow be able to manipulate that leap into plain-clothes for him

.

How? I ask you.

I have no idea and neither did he when pressed on the point.

It's purely a cop thing.... but I wasn't going to permit myself from doing the honourable thing by refusing his offer of merciful sleep. We were somewhat better off than the other half of the surveillance team. They were tenting it in the backyard of the house lot directly behind the subject house of our operation.

It was bloody cold, windy with squalling showers for the duration of the job.

They took turns in two-hour lots peering through some knot hole in the paling fence looking at the rear of the house.

Nothing happened!

Not one bloody thing!

I think even the ants were hunkered down for the duration.

A day later, worried relatives who lived across the street from said house became concerned at the non-appearance of their loved ones living so close. They opened the front door of the house that our covert attention had been organised on to be assaulted by the very acute smells of human death and decay. Murder/suicide was the verdict handed down. Too much of a good thing in dabbling in their own product so it was believed. A huge bundle of money, a cache of weapons and enough Ecstasy tablets to make the worries of the world disappear for the entire seven billion!

This murder/suicide act committed only hours before our surveillance shift began.

How's that for bad timing!

Some-one was asleep when the planning for this operation was instigated!

This had come out of the blue as I sat at my desk, the three File Carriers standing solemnly beside my position like solid sentinels waiting for orders. Angie getting impatient as I scribbled out the lines on a yellow legal pad. I didn't have a clue where these words had come from or what the words meant except to say this could be the beginning of my first Novel…maybe. Beginnings were the hardest thing to start some may say…yes, I found it difficult to begin and then to hook the beginning into a plausible story…I reread the lines excited at what they meant…a beginning!

"Joe? Joe? You with me?" Angie looked impatiently at me.

“Uh! No worries. Just sending myself a shopping reminder.” The only thing that was in my brain so quickly to say! Rather inane don’t you think?

“An entire shopping list by the looks of it…you get the bread and milk listed?”

“Huh! Yeah…um…how do you want to do this?” I asked as I folded then tucked the pages I had longhand written into my coat pocket. I would transfer them onto my computer tonight. “I will take the Murder Books from when the victim’s husband first reported her missing until Perry Matthews was arrested and charged. You take the investigative period up until the Court time. No…I’ll include that period with my first read. You take the Court time…okay? Then we change it around. The first to finish takes the Parole Board findings and there is video feed with it as well which both of us can view together…”

“That’s highly unusual, isn’t it? Being able to view a Parole Board meeting on our prisoner. I did not think that ever occurred…sounds like a plan though.”

“I would not be surprised to find that it is the Parole Board who are behind this resurgence in interest in the Case…the order had to trickle down from somewhere and the Parole Board has some weight. Either that or it came from on high along the corridors of power.”

“You think. To have them in such a position is extremely rare if it has ever happened before. I think it highly improbable and completely out of line…” She spun around to her desk to grab her coffee container before she addressed me once more. “Plus, the sudden appearance of Murray Bridge which has chucked a spanner in the works maybe pushing things along…I don’t reckon he had a thing to do with the homicide murder of Missus Jennifer Crowe…what do you reckon?” She finished after taking a quick swig of her coffee.

“He’s confessed, hasn’t he? Let’s not get ahead of ourselves, huh? We’ll do the groundwork into the where’s, what for’s, and how’s before we begin to make certain assumptions on other players on the stage.” I offered.

We hardly spoke to one another for two weeks as we slogged our way through the mountain of words that had accumulated over the killing…then we swapped, and I took on the DPP interviews and Court details. I finished first so I slogged through the Parole Board findings on six appeals our defendant had applied for. By that stage I had filled up over thirty pages of a yellow legal pad on questions, omissions in interview questions and other non-related titbits that neither rang true to me…or been followed up by the Murder Dees in charge of the investigation. Not that I was accusing them of dereliction of duty as they had produced a spotless investigation but from another set of eyes, things could look different…and usually did.

I went downstairs to the Coffee Jar to purchase two giant coffee containers for Angie and me…I figured we had earned it after sitting at our desks deep in concentration as we scanned

every word: every document. Regularly placing the important points that we had received for several weeks on end into our brains. Plus, I needed to free my back which was causing me grief the older I aged.

"Thanks Joe, I needed this…what a fuck up!"

"Whoa…don't make that assumption until we have finished the job. In a way, I have enjoyed the past four weeks or so pouring over these documents…it's what a Murder Dee does with most of his time…investigates what has gone before him. You know that girlie." I held up a hand to apologise for my gaff. "Good work Angie." I concluded as my way of apologising. "How many pages of 'mind jerks' have you filled out?" I enquired wanting to advance instead of getting mired in name calling rituals.

"Umm…twenty-four. You?"

"Thirty-one…we should be able to put this Case to bed once we do our interview cycle…but let's compare our own notes on the Case before we do anything else, huh?"

"You write larger than me." A smile to show she was just stirring, "Who do you reckon first?"

Another two weeks spent listening to each other and our opinions of things that did not seem to fit. The result was a typed report of those points attached to a new file titled 'JENNIFER CROWE…INVESTIGATION INTO HER BODY LOCATION' with a new numeric title displaying mine and Angi's initials, year, date, and murder squad code.

"Okay. The last first off…the Parole Board…that's if we can get them all together which will be a stroke of luck. Tracking each person down to interview alone will take time and a great deal of effort if we can manage it at all. Board members do not like to be singled out for such things, so I doubt we'll succeed in achieving much with them. I think we'll be left with what they've collectively written and agreed upon. They don't like having to correct their original findings. It seems to be a no-no without it being written into our 'Policy and Procedure Manual'." I surmised thinking that such a strategy would not be looked on kindly.

"Shouldn't we interview Murray Bridge first. If he was in the sights before the Board intervened for their fourth Appeals Application, they would have interviewed him before hand, wouldn't they?"

I thought about that aspect for some moments before nodding. Yes, my young partner was correct in one aspect though the Parole Board would never interview a suspect in a homicide murder who has only just slithered out of the woodwork. That was our job…

“Okay…our first interview. Murray Bridge. Do we know where he is…” I offered, then thought about it. “No…Mister Crowe…the Deceased’s husband. He itches my nose…do we know where he is?”

I heard Angie softly tap on the computer keyboard where I tend to pound the life out of the things. She made a couple of phone calls before she spun around to face me.

“He’s out of the country now. On holidays with his new family in Fiji for three weeks. Flew out last week so we are back to Murray Bridge.”

CHAPTER ELEVEN

“Bloody hell! Twelve-oh-two. There’s only two Units on the top floor. He’s living like a king so why after all this time does he confess to murdering Jennifer Crowe…he’s sitting pretty. He must be a dumb clunk.” I offered as I pushed the up button to the twelfth level. “Great views he’d have, I suspect.” I added as the Lift rose silently.

“Guilty conscious perhaps that got to him over the years. That would defy all logic and all he has achieved since the dastardly deed. All he would want to do after all this time is get the weight of guilt taken from his shoulders…some people are like that.”

“Mmm…” I looked at Angie not really believing her opinion. She raised her eyebrows and tilted her head in a questioning manner. “If pigs could fly, we’d have lighter bacon.” I added for effect in a caustic manner. That shut her up!

We stepped from the Lift into a large Lobby that had only three doors…and one was the fire exit stairs to the ground floor…a long way down to run away from flames and smoke, I thought.

I knocked on Number twelve-oh-two. I was surprised that there was no security system that would have prevented us from one; entering the Ground Floor Lobby and two; being able to access the twelfth-floor lobby area. A bit lax so I thought.

The twelve-oh-two door swung open. It was wider than a standard door which I commented on.

“Ease of getting furniture and stuff up here but it also complies with the Handicap Code, so I’ve been told. And the security system is being installed as we speak to stop people like you

from knocking on my door. You'll buzz me from the outside ground foyer area and if I want you to visit then I'll buzz you through. It then will be up to me whether I instigate the Lift door to open and for you to be deposited on the Level Twelve Lobby area and nowhere else…"

"I would have thought that it would have been installed before tenants were permitted to be in residence."

"Yeah…we all did. We've been driving the Builder and Developer mad wanting it installed. Now that you are here at my door, how can I help you two?"

We identified ourselves and produced our ID Cards. He looked at them intently before opening the door wide and standing to one side.

"Mmmph…coppers. Murder Squad people. Come through. It's not as if I haven't been expecting you." He waved his arms around inviting us to sit…but there was nowhere to sit as the furniture was still in cardboard boxes or wrapped in plastic sheeting. "Um…yeah…" He stated a little embarrassed at the predicament scratching his scalp. "Um…the tall Kitchen stools at the breakfast bar…would they be okay as an alternative to comfy lounge chairs? They're still on their way…next week so I'm told."

We both nodded as we made a beeline for the comfy-looking stools. Stepping over and around cardboard packing pieces now flattened. Hanging onto half-completed furniture pieces and flatpack articles.

"A coffee perhaps to hide my embarrassment." He chuckled uncomfortably. Smiled nervously. "This was one of the first things I unpacked. A bloke down on eight told me about a coffee beans shop at the back of Rushcutters Bay where they'll make up your preferred mix…bloody good stuff…a little expensive and hard to get to if you haven't a car but it's worth it. The chap on eight and I alternate to purchase the stuff for each other."

The chatter ceased as the man concentrated his efforts on the coffee machine. The aromas were hypnotic. He carefully slid our mugs over to us as he sat opposite on the other side of the breakfast counter.

"There." He sighed as we all took a sip. The best coffee I think I've ever tasted. I heard Angie moan blissfully.

"Arrh…a few questions if we could…" I commented as I took another sublime sip of coffee.

He nodded his approval as he placed each mug on a coaster that he had provided for the three of us. It was an obvious ploy as one would spank a recalcitrant child. I got the message to

carefully use the coaster on each occasion that I sipped on the concoction. “Sir, you have confessed to killing Missus Jennifer Crowe. Umm…how did you kill her?” Straight into it…

I was interested to see if he concurred with the Prosecutor at the time of the Trial some twelve years previously who stated that our poor Missus Crowe had been choked with her own panties…without a shred of evidence to support the statement…and the Defence did not object to the fabrication…a grand oversight!

“How!?” He looked bug-eye at me. “I strangled her…” Said as though he was discussing the recent raid by US Bunker-busters bombs dropped from B2 bombers who had flown non-stop from their mainland US airbase across the Atlantic Ocean to Iran and back again…un-bloody-believable!

“Why?”

“Yoohoo…does a Mister Bridge live here?” Someone yelled from the open front door.

“Yes.” Replied Murray Bridge as he stood from the high stool with a straight arm as though signalling to his teacher in year three that he needed to go to the toilet. He headed towards the door apologising with an upward tilt of his hand as he passed us.

I had finished my coffee and was impatiently drumming my fingers on the benchtop as he sheepishly sat down opposite us again. He could not look me in the eye as he was so embarrassed. He looked down at his half-drunk mug of coffee that had to be cold by now suggesting a refill should be in order. Both Angie and I refused the offer…he got the message!

“I think it would be better if we continue this interview at our Offices at the Police Headquarters building at Parramatta…” I sternly suggested looking at him from under hooded eyes.

“Now!?” He quickly responded. “I’ve got White Goods being delivered this afternoon and possibly the lounge suite tomorrow…or next week…more white goods the day after that…um…the bedroom furniture for the three bedrooms the day after that.”

I shook my head.

“Mister Bridge? I could arrest you on a homicide murder charge based on your confession of the other day and frog-march you off to our holding cells without another word spoken…” I scratched my scalp, pulled at my earlobe before leaning towards the man. “Tell me, why did you confess in the middle of setting up home. You would have known you would be arrested and charged which would mean this…” I spread my arms wide. “This set-up could not have happened…”

"Yeah, I know. My timing was out. My guilty conscious meant I was not thinking right. I knew I would be arrested and charged the minute you coppers faced me and this Apartment…I could rent out for the duration of my incarceration…over a thousand bucks a week for however long…a nice booty to welcome me at the end of my sentence. The money earned to purchase this unit off the plan was honestly earned with bloody long hours and shithouse working conditions let me be honest with you…yeah…lousy, hard bloody work."

I had trouble following his logic. I shook my head slowly as I glared at him…my blood pressure rising.

"Oh!?" His employment status piqued my interest. I was more than interested as to where the man had been for the past fifteen years or so…

"Fly-in/fly-out spending two days out of ten in Mount Isa where I mainly slept for the two days…working my way up from a bloody driver of those huge dump trucks to the Vehicle Movement Safety Officer that earned twice as much…yer gotta know every inch and gradient level of every track into and out of the bloody mine…those huge trucks can spin a gearbox if the gradient is too steep what with them being full of ore…yeah, hard and bloody hot yakka even though the vehicle cabins are air-conditioned…the same as the overnight cabins."

"Which mine?" Angie asked.

"Century Mine just east of Lawn Hill National Park…the AO of the world but in another way the most beautiful part of the country." He replied shaking his head.

"Um…how in hell did you end up there?" Angie asked, taking the question out of my mouth.

Bridge remained standing as he nodded, gathering up the three used coffee mugs to rinse out at the sink, placing them on a drying rack. Explaining as he did, that he was yet to receive the Dishwasher and have it connected. I was thinking he was ending the conversation…

"I reckon we deserve another coffee." He suggested as he placed three fresh mugs beside the coffee machine. Neither Angie nor I objected to the suggestion. Me coming to the realisation this was the only way we would ever gain the man's confidence or get him to keep on talking. As he fiddled with the machine he began his narrative.

"I can't remember where I met her…jeez…it has been close to sixteen…seventeen years ago. I suppose it could have been at the 'Java and Tea' Meeting Place. That is where we always met. Every Tuesday morning. Ten to eleven thirty. It did not change for the two…three years that we met…the joint is still there…I wonder if the same people are running it…maybe not as they were old people back then…" He carefully placed the steaming mugs of coffee onto new coasters in front of us. The aroma was delicious. After a sip or two he continued his

narrative. “I wanted more than a one and a half hour meeting once a week with her. I thought I was in love with her. I began to nag her about seeing her more often…about letting me into her life. Those pleadings fell on deaf ears. In the end I’d had enough…I followed her after our habitual meeting one day. Guess what, she went two suburbs over to another dining place where she shared a meal with another bloke who could have been me. A young bloke. Clean skinned. Looking fit. She carried on the same with him as she had with me…she was nothing but a floozy. I waited…one and a half hours. She went home so I thought. Let herself into the house as though she owned it. Half hour later a bloke turned up in a fancy car. Parked under a carport beside the house. Let himself into the house with a key as though he owned the place…my coffee will be cooling too much…” He took several sips. Nodded. “The longer I sat there the madder I got…eventually I walked up the front path and began banging on the door…Jenni answered…I can’t remember what happened after that. My mind went blank.” He shook his head to try and clear the cobwebs but that didn’t work. “The next thing I know I was on the floor in the entry hallway. Jenni lying near me. Dead. I’d choked her, I’m sure. I had blood dripping down my forehead. I have no idea how I succumbed to that injury unless I bumped it as I fell to the floor. It stopped after a while.”

He went to pick up his mug but spilt some as his hands were shaking so much. He ran his hands over his forehead as he quickly wiped up the spilt coffee trail, carefully but gently rinsing the cleaning cloth out in the Kitchen sink. An OCD freak I thought to myself. He returned to face us, taking a couple of sips of coffee before continuing.

"I remember things in fragmented, slow-motion sequences. I thought I should bury her…the next thing that I can recall was I was standing in the driveway looking down towards the street realising that my car did not belong at this address and people could suss that out. I walked towards the rear shed which was an extension to the rear garage looking for a spade…a shovel not knowing where I was going to dig her grave. I’d walked past several raised veggie patches…something like six in total…no…four…a couple in fallow. I didn’t even think, I stripped off to my underdaks and dug out a ditch about 160 centimetres deep. Placed her body gently into the hole and covered it over…”

“If this was her home wouldn’t that be one of the first places the investigating coppers would have looked?” Angie asked quietly. I was annoyed as I did not want to interrupt his discourse. I coughed to denote my disapproval. “What then?” Angie ignored my ire. She needed to judge when a suspect was about to tell all. Spill his guts…he was almost there at the end of his confession!

“What!? What then! I…I hosed myself down, dried myself off with a towel that I got from the shed, got dressed and got the fuck outa there…I headed north. First stop I think was Singleton or somewhere around there to buy some clothes, travelling gear…you know razor, toothbrush. I eventually ended up in Camooweal in north-central Queensland. Took a job there on the night shift in a Roadhouse off the main drag…stayed there for two years about after which I took a fly-in/fly-out job from Mount Isa to the Central Mines just out from the

Lawn Hill National Park. Have done three four-year stints rising to Vehicle Management Mine Safety Routine Chief for the entire mine…good bloody pay but long hours and tiring long days."

I nodded…it was as I had thought, the story so full of holes I doubted the guilt of the man but so many years had passed he had convinced himself of his guilt whether it was true or not.

"Mister Bridge? We would like to interview you in our office away from so many distractions. Say 1030 hours next Tuesday morning. We will expect you. If you do not appear at that time an arrest warrant will be issued for your immediate apprehension…understand?"

The man nodded. His head lowered. The picture of a guilty man whom I was still not convinced was guilty of murder. Yes, guilty of disposing of a dead body but murder? Not on.

CHAPTER TWELVE

I pulled up opposite a neat bungalow on the high side of the street. A large Pepper Tree afforded shade over most of the house. A double carport hung off the front of the residence in a street lined with neat, well-maintained pre-war bungalows…pre-first world war construction.

We sat there listening to the ticking of the cooling engine. Saying nothing. I was waiting for Murray Bridge's patience to wear thin. He eventually broke, shaking his head.

"What are we doing here?" He asked nonplussed, twisting around in his seat to view up and down the street that he had never driven down in his life!

"Do you recognise that house?" I asked, jutting my chin in the direction of the house on the opposite side of the street.

"Should I?" Bridge replied a little flummoxed. Glancing then examining the house. Shaking his head. "No!" He added forcefully. "No…there was a big tree like that, but it was in the neighbouring front yard. The house had a steep driveway which flattened out as it reached the front of the house. A simple single lightweight carport hung off the side of the house, not at the front like that one…and that one is a double carport." He tried to indicate the incline of the driveway with his arm on a slant.

“That’s where your Jenni and her husband lived for much of their married life. Mister Crowe sold it on around the time of the Court Case…don’t know who lives there now.” I offered, glancing over at our suspect.

“No…her house? No! There’s nothing here…up or down the street that twigs my memory…it’s been what? Fourteen…fifteen years but nothing…no…nothing at all. That’s where she and her husband lived! Nothing like the house I buried her in the back yard of... in one of the veggie patches.” Bridge repeated several times.

“Okeydokey…back to the office, Angie. Mister Bridge, you can make a formal statement, sign it and then you are free to go.” I announced.

“You are not going to arrest me!?”

“No…I very much doubt that you killed Missus Crowe but you’re not off the hook…we have you for illegally disposing of a body, failing to tell the relevant authorities of an illegal death and failing to remain with the body until the relevant authorities arrived which could land you with a five-year stint in prison…so stay around”.

I felt sure he was not going to run off again…he’d suffered with a guilty conscience for umpteen years now, so he knew running away was not the panacea for a clear and innocent mind…

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

All new Bosses have their own way of ‘bedding in’ with Squad members. Most adhere to the Management Training Manual, but it would appear DSI Veronica Faye had her own method.

As I was the elder statesperson of the Dees on the floor, I was the first interviewed…not about my success, my thoughts on my colleagues but on my past failures.

Go figure!

My mind did an immediate rewind to my first failure and its resurrection last year with the death of my first snitch and the subsequent investigation that involved him…reluctantly on my part on that first failure while I was under the tutelage of DI John Church aka Abbey. He became not only my first tutor but as time ticked on, he also became my surrogate father…

As I began to describe my frustration, my sense of failure and the thought I wasn't meant to be a Homicide Detective, it was Abbey's constant support and drive to continue, to delve in different directions that softened that sense of disappointment …those words now spilt forth in a surprising flow of revelation in front of this new boss.

I had no idea what my new boss thought of my offering though I wasn't much impressed. Her wish to end the interview after she made a flurry of notes was that she appreciated my self-evaluation, honesty, and the ability to not be afraid to show my emotions. I had no idea what that meant to her, but it worried me as the depth of my revelations sure concerned me.

An undefended moment which should not have occurred…but those moments occurred more often the older I got…

I stood expecting our time was over especially as her phone buzzed. She held up her hand to stay me. I stood at the office door, my hand on the door handle.

"Where?" There was silence as she listened. "Who? The father! With the son suspected. Do we know where he is? Seventeen…shit! Um…pass the information through to Joe Lind's iPad…yes…" She looked up at me. "As far as I can tell you are the only Dee on the floor without a homicide case…" She again held up her hand to shut me up. "Your current case involves finding the body of a woman murdered fifteen years ago. Her killer is in prison serving a twelve without any parole. He is to be released next winter…you can afford to lay off that Case to concentrate yours and Angie's efforts on this Case. A Case that looks sadly like the son has killed his father…okay. I have work to do with the rest of the Squad floor and the civilian clerical staff which should keep me busy for another two weeks. Keep me across your investigation, okay?"

"Yes Boss." I replied as I opened her office door looking for Angie. I felt I must impress this new Boss with an apology in the way I had conducted myself in the interview. It never revealed itself. I was not that concerned at what she thought of me…okay…maybe a little…

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

"What have we got?" I asked the 'Sign On' Officer as I signed my name, badge number, time, and date. I was expected to sign off but after a few hours of site examination things usually got a little tardy with the Officer usually filling in the time of our departure.

I walked towards a familiar figure dressed in her finest forensic outfit making her look like a large version of a Smurf lacking the white curled cap! That would have rounded out the outfit beautifully.

“Hello gorgeous…” I purred as I ran my hip up beside hers. Me beginning to giggle as other forensic personnel looked on at our charade.

“Don’t you dare, old man…or at least do it a little slower otherwise I’ll tell your missus that you’re too fast. She is watching us from over there.” Dee Dee Symonds nodded towards my wife as she stood upright. A pout to show my wife she was enjoying the banter.

The two of them had been friends longer than I had known Tellie. In fact, our marriage strengthened their relationship. They began going out for a meal, show, or movie every fortnight until Tellie had Samantha then Ali. The arrangement taken up again with vigour after the breast-feeding cycle was over. The good side of the fortnightly deal was that Tellie could point out the better Restaurants within proximity for us to frequent now that the girls were old enough to be by themselves for an evening.

I stood to turn and watch the Paramedics wheel out an older woman, her face still smeared with blood. She was heavily sedated, an oxygen mask over her face. A younger version was wheeled out behind her, she too sedated. Little chance of getting any information out of them while they were still on-site…and you can bet your house that the medical fraternity at whatever hospital the two were being conveyed to would not be happy to see me and my partner trying to wake the patients up out of their groggy state.

I punched the side of my thigh as there were no witnesses that we could question. I had many questions and very few answers, and I wouldn't be satisfied anytime soon.

“Please, could you all stop jabbering to give me a reasonable assertion of what occurred this morning.” I angrily addressed the number of forensic trace and forensic pathologists crowding out their various areas of interest. They all seemed to stand to attention, uncertainty looking at me.

Tellie stepped forward, bless her heart.

“Yes, you have some idea what occurred this morning, Officer Lind?” Everyone knew she was my wife but that made minor difference to the pecking order on site. She and Dee Dee were on a similar grading. The Leading Forensic Officers on homicide sites. It was rare they were on-site together.

“Detective? Um…breakfast as usual where a fight…an argument broke out which was not unusual. Mister Ramelli…”

“That was their surname…Ramelli…Greek? No? Czech? Serbian? Yes?” I didn’t know why the surname seemed so important to me…it just did!

Tellie and Dee Dee agreed that the family name was Greek, but the family were Serbian refugees from the Czech/Serbian/Macedonian war of the late nineteen-nineties coming to Australia to escape the carnage…whatever Paul Ramelli had experienced during his time with Macedonian forces obviously had a severe effect on him. Tellie thinking aloud wondered how many refugees from that part of the world and from Palestine suffered from PTSD left undiagnosed and unattended with them given refugee status into Australia…a lot, she surmised sadly.

“Ironic, huh? Um…the husband hits his wife in the nose and mouth hard which also was not unusual. The son stepped in to protect his mother shoving his old man away. The old bloke fell to the floor giving young Paul a chance to kick him several times in the head…then he ran.” Tellie continued. “By the time Paul senior had found his legs and gained the front fence, the boy was halfway down the block. The old man knew there would be plenty of chances to get his own back, so he went back inside to have his breakfast and to continue to argue with his wife.” She looked over at her friend for confirmation that she was on the right track at that moment. She continued. “It wasn’t that much later they heard the clunky diesel motor of Paul Junior’s 4WD start up in the front yard, parked on the lawn which always infuriated the old man. We’re not sure but we think the old man may have held onto the bullbar of the clapped-out 4WD as the son drove it into that brick support pier squashing the old bloke between the bullbar and the brick pier.” She shook her head before blowing her nose and wiping the tears from her eyes. She continued shakily. “It could have been an accident as he quickly reversed the truck into a tight circle T-boning backwards into his father’s pride and joy…that we don’t think was an accident. The collision caused the old bloke to lose his grip on the bullbar…that and the injuries he received when he was squashed against the brickwork pier perhaps. Maybe the son didn’t know his father’s prone body lay in front of him, but either way he placed the 4WD in first gear and tramped it! Both front and rear wheels ran over the old bloke. In his terror to get well away, young Paul tore up the lawn, jumped over the flower bed and the kerb and gutter and in a cloud of smoke sped off down the street to destinations unknown…that’s about it, Joe. A lot of that is fact based on evidence before you, the words of the daughter who saw it all though her rendition was decidedly shaky, and we made assumptions from her confused and tortured vocal evidence…”

I nodded before turning to walk towards the brick pier that hadn’t suffered too much damage. A couple of scrape marks, a chip off a corner or two…that was all. If I looked closely, I would detect blood and hair scrapings on one corner of the brick pier…

“Senior Detective Lind? If you could stay away from that area, please. We have done little forensic trace examination there…”

I raised my hand as an apology, nodded.

“Sorry, Forensic Lead Officer Missus Lind.” I gave her a faint smile as I backtracked to the nose of the wrecked car that had been Ramelli Senior’s pride and joy. I beckoned to Angie.

“Contact Roads and Traffic…the Vehicle Registration Branch. Check on the registration, the number plates and the owner’s name and address…arrh…then check with the License Bureau on Paul Junior’s licence details. When you have that put a call into Comcentral requesting an ‘All Points Bulletin’ under my name giving them the necessary details on the vehicle. Approach with caution. The driver may be armed and is wanted in connection with his father's death.”

She nodded as she walked to our Unmarked to obey those commands away from the throng of Officers that seemed to have expanded as nothing but ‘onlookers’ as time went on. I was talking to the second on-site Officer who still looked green having lost his early dose of Maccas when he arrived on site to see the carnage left behind by the young bloke. He swore that this would be the last one…he was resigning that afternoon regardless of what I said trying to get him to change his mind.

Angie opened the door of the Unmarked to beckon me over.

“Arrh…Boss? Paul…or Paul Junior…or Paulo or Paulo Ramelli Junior has never held a Driver’s Licence…never. Yes, the beat-up 4WD was registered to Paul Ramelli Junior four years ago…nothing since…it is now unregistered and uninsured…”

I nodded and began to walk away. I had half expected that conclusion.

“Boss? The vehicle has been located. The Dunes…north of Wanda Beach…”

“I know where the Dunes is. I surfed there a couple of times whenever I could bludge a lift there and back home again in my teenage years.” I turned away from her as images of a fast right and left-hander flashed across my memory. Some said it went to pack once they began extending the east-west main runway out into Botany Bay and developing the Port Botany Container terminal. I didn’t know…I hadn’t been back to the spot.

Angie cut across those memories…

“And Boss…young Paul was still inside the vehicle. Self-inflected death by carbon monoxide poisoning…he chopped himself…”

“Figures…” Is all I said. It was the only fair way for this Case to end. We’d now have a couple of days at the Office preparing a Coroner’s Report which took about as much time as a

Homicide Case took to resolve itself in computer time. I wasn't affected either way by his passing…life always ends in death in so many ways…and Angie was a quicker typist and a more successful composition author than I, so I would proofread her words as she typed them out. Suggesting minor changes that did not alter the meaning of the report…but I felt I must contribute something!

I have dealt with every type of homicide during my career and nothing fazes me now.

Still, I kicked a plod of lawn out of anger, frustration or distress for the family who had suffered for years under their despotic and cruel husband and father. That or what Paul Junior had damaged in his hurried progress to be rid of this address. I slapped my thigh and turned to walk back to our Unmarked with Angie still half in/half out of the vehicle.

"Arrh…Tracey Myers…Detective-in-Training Tracey Myres. What do we know of her? Her name mentioned in passing in the murder notes of Levi Sol and Harry Newcombe before she offered her resignation. Why? What caused her to resign?"

The question came out of the blue and was not related to anything that happened in the front yard of the Ramelli family that morning. It was typical me and my meandering thoughts which some people had trouble keeping up with.

Angie looked at me lopsidedly as though I was slightly mad.

"Is it important Joe?" She asked, a lop-sided tilt of her head signalling her confusion.

"Yes. It's a loose end…why did she resign at that point? Find out. Find out what she is doing now. What is her current address…we may have a chat with her…okay?" I didn't notice Angie's half-smile or grimace at the orders…we were kilometres away physically and in our minds mentally to the Jennifer Crowe body location case….

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Doctors were amazed at the injuries the old woman had suffered without seeking medical treatment for years. Because of this, we were not permitted to interview the woman for some weeks as she underwent multiple surgeries. We still had plenty to do to fill out our time. Interviewing close neighbours, family and relatives and the local police.

The address was well known to the local coppers who had 'regular' visitations to the home at the instigation of near neighbours. This was not surprising but what was, was the lack of back-up and return visits by those same local coppers to charge the senior male Ramelli with a raft of complaints starting with assault with intention to maim…it did not need the cry of accusation by any other member of the family. It could now be undertaken as a formal statement as the Law has been changed…but it was rarely done which was common practise…too much paperwork was the usual excuse with little result as it was a quick roundabout when the crime hit the Courts! The accused was out on the street that afternoon returning to the family home to continue with the cycle of hurt…physically and mentally!

Surprisingly, while young Paulo had a poor record of attending school which was mirrored right through primary to secondary school, his assessment had him in the higher ten percent of the class with comments like high intelligence, above average attentive and retentive gradings…his IQ was in the top one percent of the school…something I could not accept without some mental processes of my own.

When we at last could interview Missus Ramelli, all our efforts, assumptions and interviews were confirmed.

It took both of us almost two weeks to round out the investigation, gather up the forensic trace evidence and autopsy results of both Ramelli males into a logical report as a quality account of the terrible life of the Ramelli family. The final report to submit to the coroner…we then swung our concentration back onto the Missus Jennifer Crowe's body whereabouts trying to remember where we were in the investigation before being taken off the Case…a hard thing to do!

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

"Harry…good to see you again."

"It wasn't that long ago Joe. Sol's funeral…poor bastard." He replied with a smile. "Yeah…here he had all these plans for after he retired but up and dies of cancer two years after he walked off the squad floor…eight years after I retired. It's no good planning for these things as you will always be disappointed." He lamented.

Yep…Harry hadn't changed much since the days he was working on the Squad floor. Sol and he held the record for the longest running partners in the Murder Squad. Harry had taken Sol under his wing straight from the Academy…in the early to mid-seventies. Been a successful

partnership for all those years. A couple of well-reported and savage homicides that would always ensure their continued success and their names constantly in the public's eye.

"Heard on the grapevine you two are reinvestigating Jennifer Crowe's death…a bit long in the tooth, ain't it? I reckon the guy is close to being released…wasn't there something about 'No body…No parole' associated with this Case?"

I nodded. I didn't want to give too much away.

"Yer know? That case was unique in our career. Sol and I faced no body, relying solely on circumstantial evidence, forensic traces, and the absence of remains for the Prosecution Case. Little more. Very 'iffy.' Both Sol and I were a little…umm…not concerned…a little troubled with the whole set-up. The DPP wanted blood and the more we found out about Jennifer Crowe's tête-à-têtes with various young men that went back to the beginning of her marriage with her hubby, Geof Crowe the more they wanted to crucify her as the guilty party. Discussions with Missus Crowe's sister seemed to reveal a marriage that was up and down like so many others. Mostly financial stress but they worked it out as time went on. Most who knew both described them as a typical young married couple…nothing more, nothing less. We approached Psychiatrists and Counsellors who all agreed that something was missing in the marriage…or in the woman's character…what that was they couldn't or wouldn't say."

"Was Matthews your only suspect?"

"No…jeez no…we had two others who we thought at the time were more solid in their guilt than Matthews. Jerry Caldicott was our favoured Number One…"

"What happened…his name doesn't ring any bells…we never came across it as we examined all the paperwork including your formal and informal notes…that's a bit unusual isn't it? No mention of your Number One suspect."

"Yeah…no…he was the victim of a single vehicle accident out of Hay in southwest NSW. Whether it was an accident with him trying to avoid a collision with a Roo, a sheep, a Wombat, or another animal wandering on the back road as it was sunset, we'll never know. He picked the most solid tree around to smash into if that gives you any reason for your nose to itch. This was some days after we had interviewed him and had escalated him to our Number One suspect…I'm still sure about him. The other was Murray Bridge. Missus Crowe terminated her association with him several days prior to being reported missing by her spouse. Bridge was terribly upset about being dismissed so abruptly, but he disappeared…there's still an open arrest warrant out on him I would imagine…bin some fifteen…sixteen years so he could be anywhere…who knows!"

"Forget him…his sudden appearance and confession to choking Jennifer Crowe we recorded with his Statement counter signed the other day. His sudden appearance and confession

reignited interest in the case. He has lived with guilt for years since burying Jennifer Crowe's body."

"He has confessed to the homicide!? To burying her body? Where?"

"Yes…to just burying the body…not committing the homicide. We are more than sure of that…we will charge him with the illegal disposal of a body at the proper time so that leaves Matthews and Caldicott as our suspects…what about Mister Crowe, the husband? Was he examined thoroughly?"

"Nah, he was out of the picture early on and when his wife's exploits started appearing in Court, he was a broken man. On two occasions an Ambulance had to be called because he collapsed…the second time with a fair dinkum heart attack…closed the Court for a couple of hours on each occasion."

I nodded, again unsure as to the veracity of that information. To me the heart attacks…or supposed heart attacks did not clear him of guilt…or prove his innocence. I was about to mention my thoughts but decided to hold my counsel. The Case was the man's shining glory which he proudly lived off for all these years after his retirement day. I wondered what Case my crowning glory would be. The one that became my proudest moment through my retirement years. It suddenly occurred to me that I was not as moody as I once had been and this chase and gathering of facts I was enjoying. I threw a smile at Angie who had no idea why she was the recipient…giving me a blank look as a reply!

"Mister Crowe? He had a rock-solid alibi. Three of his friends vouched for his attendance at their usual long weekend get-away for the boys. I can't remember where…either up or down the coast fishing all night and drinking all day…I can remember those days on fishing weekends with the mates…" A smile ripped away the frown that had anchored across his brow.

Again, I wondered on whether sufficient examination had occurred on the alibi. A check with the mates may now turn up a different story. I made a note to chase out the three mates who would all be middle-aged men by now…or there-abouts.

I guess we stayed at Harry's place for another thirty…forty-five minutes with the conversation revolving to the characters who had once trod the Homicide Squad floor. It took me some moments to realise that Harry was a good decade ahead of me slotting into the Squad straight from the Academy with the help of SDI John Church aka 'Abbey' a good ten years before me. We both agreed that he was the best Boss that ever warmed the Murder Squad Chief's chair…Denny Turner came in a close second and with the unexpected and sudden death of the woman, we have been led by a series of good people but none at the levels of Church or Turner.

“Abbey still alive?” Harry asked as we gathered on his front porch. “He was Sol’s favourite Boss by a long shot. He and Turner did not see eye to eye on many occasions as though the two had this secret pissing contest going on that none of us knew about.” He shook his head. “Is he still alive. The last I heard he and missus were living in the wilds of the Flinders Ranges in South Australia…”

“Yeah…with both loving it…heat and flies and everything else yer got when bush camping. Banjo…Abbey’s missus needed an operation. They came home for that with it not going as well as expected. I think their travelling days are over as Abbey won’t go anywhere without his beloved Banjo…and she finds it too difficult to move about. They are in a Grannie Flat at the back of their original house…the son and his wife and kids in the main house where they can keep a close eye on both…the Mobile Home under wraps…Abbey won’t sell it…he says it’s worth keeping. I don’t know, a one hundred-thousand-dollar investment just sitting there up on blocks does not seem right to me….”

“To sell it would involve him recognising and accepting that his roving days are over. Now there’s the pity. Life always ends in death I always say when you least want it to, destroying whatever plans may have been wished for most of yer adult years.” Harry philosophised. “Huh…” He shook his head and smiled. “That’s why I have always been reticent in planning trips away too far in advance…. two Cruises a year keeps me interested in life.” He nodded, sure that his look on life was the way to go.

I did not know either way.

“Amen to that.” I added softly feeling melancholy at the thought that my plans for retirement may never come to fruition…and when I thought about it, my plans for retirement were not yet formulated which shat me off!!

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

“Yes? How can I help you?” She asked pleasantly as she opened her front door to our knock after we had waited. A yell of ‘just a moment’ from inside quelling my want to knock again.

She was a tired, late thirty-something year-old woman balancing a young one off her hip as she answered the door. A dirty napkin over her shoulder as though we had interrupted feed time. She looked pregnant again.

“I thought so as soon as I seen yers…Dees.” She offered quietly as she glanced at our ID Cards. “It’s bin a while…what do yers want with me now? I left the Force behind …oh…years ago now.”

“Looks as though you’ve got your hands full what with the one asleep on your hip and another in the oven…Tracey Myers is it?”

She shushed me quiet.

“My married name is Tracey Willoughby…I would have preferred Myers-Willoughby but there are still some against that sort of thing…like my father bless his cotton socks. Aylee is number six and the one in the oven number seven…I’d like to make eight before I turn forty in three years’ time…pushing my luck, huh?”

What can you say in return?

“Perry Matthews…” Angie whispered, leaning towards the woman.

The change in the young woman was instant. She stood upright with real anger in her eyes. The tot on her hip roused slightly before settling again.

“Let me put Aylee down before we get too deep into the conversation. That guy will be my nemesis for my entire life. Guaranteed! Um…follow me through to the Kitchen. No babies…none of that baby regurgitation smell that so many detest.”

The house smelled like regurgitated Formula…a smell that I have always hated. I used to leave the room when Tellie got Al or Sam chucking up their breast milk or later, their Formula…hated it! The Kitchen was large, clean, not a smell of baby yuck or toys anywhere. She had chucked the smelly, stained linen cloth she had over her shoulder and had changed her blouse for a tight-fitting T-shirt. By way of explanation, she stated that T-shirts were easier to clean, dry and were cheaper than blouses which she had on when she had answered the door to our knock as she had been out that morning.

“Okay…I could do with a coffee. You two? Please sit while I get the coffee machine going.” Soon the large room and attached Family Room were filled with the aromatic smells of good coffee roast. Not excellent, but good enough.

She eventually settled opposite us with a weary sigh…it’s a police thing even if she had left the Force some twelve-fifteen years previously…sitting opposite the subject that is.

“You offered your resignation one week into the trial period…suddenly…without warning. Why? We were permitted to access your Personal File…there’s nothing in writing to give us an explanation. Why? Have you any idea why?”

“You don’t know! It’s not written into the thick layers of folios on the Case…nowhere!? Bloody hell, that’s got to be a first…” She took a sip of her steaming coffee. “Um….” She glanced at both of us. “I have no idea how the Boss found out, but she was seething when she confronted me…um…I was having an affair with Matthews…to me the poor third level suspect after the guy who died in a one vehicle collision with a tree out bush somewhere and the second-best suspect…a funny name…”

“Murray Bridge…” I reminded her. Her revelation surprised me, but she showed no remorse. Time may have softened her attitude.

“Yeah…that’s right. Murray Bridge…his parents must have conceived him in that border town…” She shook her head. “Yeah…he disappeared off the planet, so they settled on Perry Matthews as their next best choice…a poor choice until he confessed to me…three times in fact during our dalliance…which changed my opinion of him being a good bloke…he said it was the neatest way to kill someone. One hard blow with a hammer to the top of the head. Little bleeding. Little reaction and no screams of agony. He promised me that was the way I would go if I didn’t do as he ordered…that was the end for me…a week later I’m fronting the Boss. I’ve always wondered if it were he who put me in…just in spite as it meant nothing to him either way…”

There was silence for some moments as we all pondered on that score, until I exploded.

“Jee-eezuzz! Fucking hell! Do you realise what would happen if this ever got out…even now!? With the guy walking out a free man inside twelve months!! He could sue the pants off us and the New South Wales Government and Police Force!!!” It suddenly occurred to me that both Ang and I were now included in the small circle of knowledge and were subject to instant dismissal if the truth ever emerged! Angie was young enough to start again but with me fast approaching retirement age in five-six years’ time, the loss of all my entitlements was enormous! Thinking selfishly of the effects it would have on me…. I was almost sick, and I must have gone a shade of grey that wasn’t healthy as Angie looked worriedly at me.

“I’ve got to ask the question…” Angie interrupted my thoughts. “Perry Matthews was aware of the dalliance and what it meant…a mistrial and a get out of jail card quick smart but he failed to speak up. Why? Wasn’t he aware of the ramifications of his and your actions. Was his Solicitor aware of the situation at the same time? How long did this affair go on for?”

Multiple questions were not a good interviewing technique. I must remember to talk this over with Angie as she did it too many times to mention.

Tracey shrugged.

“Um…he was down as Number Three suspect on Levi Sol and Harry’s list…way down to such an extent they were ignoring his involvement. They permitted me to question Matthews…it just happened, and it continued up until the first week of the Trial. We are talking what…two years I suppose…a little less but does the time mean much? The fact that we had an affair is the paramount cause for a mistrial even now…isn’t it?”

“Bloody hell yeah! And no-one twigged?” I was shaking my head in disbelief.

“Someone must have because Denny Turner sure did know, and she acted immediately and decisively…I was out the door on that same morning she confronted me so someone must have gotten into her ear before I confessed.”

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

We were heading for the Lift Lobby a little unsure of what our next move would be. Old Harry Newcombe again more than likely as he seemed to hold out on us when we had spoken to him several days before.

My Mobile tittered before beginning the open chord of Jingle Bells.

“Mister Lind? This is the Chancellor at the Hunter Regional Research Centre here in Newcastle. There has been a slight accident in the Research Laboratory where your young daughter works. She is fine but is in hospital under observation…”

The pit of my stomach tried to join my feet in my comfortable shoes as no-one is fine if they need to stay in hospital under observations for more than twenty-four hours. My voice rose. My hands shook.

“What Hospital?” No small talk or how’s your father. I was on the verge of panic. Angie could see the alarm in my whole being and steered me over to a bench seat at one end of the Lobby.

“The Hunter…she’s fine…”

“Thank you, sir.” Thoughts mingled. Actions stalled. An immediate image crossed my mind of my son’s crumpled body lying beside my wrecked Ducati motorbike…and his premature

death years later after a slow, downhill struggle to survive…then I snapped back to reality wondering if my genius daughter was headed the same way.

I immediately speed-dialled Tellie who had just picked up Sam and Al from school. In situations like this she always acted clear-headed…picking up my other two daughters from school was not even on the horizon for me…

"I'm taking the girls home to pack a bag each. I'll pack one for you…arrh…can you grab your Unmarked to take us up to Newcastle…you know, bells, whistles, lights, and siren?"

"You know I can't, Tells. They would have my balls."

"We cannot have that now can we, dear…must consider your masculinity. It could jeopardise our marriage, my love…just trying to lighten things up. We will take our 4WD instead. I will drive because I am more experienced with driving at higher speeds. Additionally, if I get caught speeding, it will not have significant consequences, but it could impact your job if you were caught speeding. Is that acceptable?"

Tellie caned the life out of our aging V8 4WD as we sped up the M1 towards Newcastle. How we weren't booked for speeding had me beat. A look towards my two girls in the back seat seemed to indicate they were enjoying the speed we were going…ten to fifteen kilometres an hour faster than the signposted one ten on the motorway from the Hornsby on-ramp up to the Newcastle fly-over. Me? I was hanging onto the grab-handle above the window for dear life…I should not have shown my complete lack of confidence in my wife's driving at high speed…but she got us to our destination safely.

We parked at the first available parking spot whether we were permitted to or not. A race to Admissions followed by a frantic rush to the ICU.

Danni was propped up in a hospital bed reading a scientific journal. She did not seem to mind being left in the main windy corridor of the ICU. She looked up at us wondering what all the fuss was about as we slewed to a stop around her bed.

"Bloody hell! What are youse guys doing here?" Was her first comment. "I'm not hurt…just a couple of cuts from flying shrapnel…and ringing ears. There is no space in ICU, so I have been parked out here until there is. They want to keep me in overnight just for observation…on what I have no idea although they are saying I have a case of slight concussion caused by the explosion and the consequent blast wave, but hell, I feel fine! A couple of faint bruises when I was flung backwards into the Lab's entry doors…nothing serious." Her frostiness thawed quickly as we all hugged and kissed our girl…all of us happy we were there.

We stayed with her until we were asked to leave as she was wheeled into the ICU ward proper. We could pick her up around ten the following morning all going well. Ring us first, the Ward Sister instructed calmly.

We booked a Serviced Apartment at Hawks Nest for ten days, the first time in yonks we have all been together…a special occasion that we all seemed to enjoy with the girls sharing the large king-sized bed while Tellie and I were downgraded to two singles in one of the other bedrooms.

On the last day as we were packing up and cleaning out the four-bedroom Apartment my work's mobile buzzed its ugly tone.

"Joe? You are due back here at work next Monday morning. Forget that. Angie will pick you up first thing Monday morning wherever you decide to spend Sunday night. Accommodation on the Force. The acting Deputy Commissioner Major Crimes, Harold Bartholamew has gone missing…we suspect foul play. He has been holidaying with his missus up near you at Raymond Terrace. Has a daughter and son-in-law living there…or around there somewhere on a small acreage agistment farm."

'Near us!?' I thought. *'Not bloody next door that's for bloody sure!'*

"What are we expected to do, Boss?" I was not keen in having to say good-bye to my family on the weekend to spend a night alone up here somewhere waiting for my young partner to pick me up on the Monday morning.

"Lend a hand. Show that the Murder Squad is taking part of the load…"

"When did he go missing, Boss?"

"Hasn't been seen since he took the family dog for a walk early morning three days ago…help out, will ya? The local Uniform guys and SES volunteers are conducting the search…see if there is anything untoward in his disappearance…you know the ropes…anything suspicious-like…you are good at things like that…keep me across your examinations. Okay?"

The comments on my detective skills did not satisfy me, but Missus Jennifer Crowe's body had been buried for fifteen to eighteen years, so an extra day or two made little difference. I must keep an eye on the Boss using feminine ways to get what she wanted. A straight-out order would do fine as far as I was concerned. This female thing was not to my liking, and I will tell her such one of these days…

I wasn't thrilled by the request as we still had our hands full with the Jennifer Crowe disappearance and homicide…we still had a long way to go, and the release of the guilty Perry

Matthews was getting closer…next Winter…with still nothing definite as to the location of Crowe's body. I knew we were getting close having identified the area…the Drummoyne Peninsular…and the important veggie patch would be the item that confirmed the location…if the veggie patches still existed. The neighbour's tree in the front yard would be another yardstick as I doubted it would ever be cut down. It was a 'Greenie hotspot' around that area and with few adult trees in the area, the loss of just one was a grand sin and noticeable by all.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

I was sitting outside the Motel Room I had booked. Two separate bedrooms as Angie was a constant complainer about my snoring. Sipping on a 'motel latte' that required an acquired taste.

She drove up slowly unsure as to whether this was her destination until she saw me enjoying the mid-morning sunshine.

I helped her unload her stuff; enough for several months away from home I thought.

"How long do you think we'll be here?" She asked as she glanced at her two large wheeled cases. "No longer than a couple of weeks I hope…um…visited Sophie on my way home last night…had our Unmarked so why not take advantage…" She heard me growl as that was not included in the permission for her to drive it without my presence. I saw her smile before she turned away from me. "She is going great guns. The operation to place a plate and screws on her shoulder blade was successful and her left leg is healing well…the bloody leg looks like a road map there are so many stitches up and down that left leg. They're hopeful she'll be able to walk again but not without a walking cane and a limp. Sophie says no…that's not gunna happen."

"You could bet that she wouldn't like that." I commented. "I guess it could be the end of her building sports cars from the ground up…and I'd be worried about her retaining her position with the Force which will really piss her off…"

"Can't she slot into Police Intelligence? You know, where you were the Boss for a couple of months…"

"Not at present…there's some agreement that the Unit does not exceed twelve members, a Clerk and the Boss when it was first conceived…don't know why but they've had a dozen members for a while and I can't see that dropping to permit her allotment…sorry. Bloody hell…you've got enough gear to last a couple of months up here…no longer than a week or

two just to show we care about a Boss. A bloody week at the most, I reckon. First things first. Get your stuff hanging in the closet while I try to finish off this excuse for coffee. Then we'll visit the local cop shop before stopping into the Chief's daughter and son-in-law's place to have a word with the man's distraught wife…I presume she is in distress at her husband's unexplained disappearance."

"How long have they been married?" Angie asked as she wheeled in her second suitcase from our Unmarked.

"Haven't a clue…why do you ask?"

She shrugged, gaving me a condescending smirk.

"Do you know the Acting Chief? The bloke in question?" She asked as she carefully hung her clothes already on their own hangers. Mostly slack suits with blouses of various colours to brighten up the bland Cop Force uniforms.

"Mmm…yeah… Harold Bartholamew…not closely but I've been around as the guy climbed the promotion ladder much to some people's horror or humour. Some say he is a prime example of the principle of being promoted to a position above his limitations…don't know about that but I felt he was a round peg in a square hole for the past couple of promotions…my opinion only…arrh…any movement on the Jennifer Crowe Case while I've been with my family for two glorious weeks? This is the longest period we have all been together in several years, not counting our monthly weekend trips to Melbourne during her posting there.

"Glad you had the time together, Boss…arrh…the Crowe Case…not much movement…I'm beginning to think we will never find that address which is bloody frustrating as I believe we have narrowed down its location to the Drummoyne Headland…there can't be too many large trees around that area…"

"It's been what? Almost twenty years. The blasted tree could have been knocked down years ago." I offered light-heartedly. "Or fallen during one of those storms Sydney is famous for."

"Mmm…I don't reckon." Angie replied. "Not amongst all those greenies who live in that area. I'm thinking of using Google Maps, Flyover and Streetscape when we get back to the office. That's got to be an easier way to tackle the problem than cruising the streets day after day."

"Mmm…" She had lost me. Google Maps, Streetscapes, Flyovers, etcetera…who in all honesty knew what they were…

CHAPTER TWENTY

We visited the local small police station, which is staffed only on weekdays until 5 PM. Going on their apathy and unenthusiasm, they were already at five in the afternoon when it was still just past ten in the morning. Perhaps the Acting Deputy Chief was disliked as he shoved his weight around every time that he holidayed at his daughter's residence nearby. That would not go down well with them! But that was not the man I knew…he was more languid. Quieter so not to frighten a bloody mouse!

Unimpressed, we then visited the SES HQ site some five kilometres along a popular walking trail that circled back on itself through thick bush.

"There is one other that is used by the locals, but it ends at the riverbank and you've gotta retrace your steps…not as popular as this one and is rougher as well which makes for jogging a little harder…broken bones: sprained ankles it's known for. The Head Copper doesn't take his dog for a walk; he jogs alongside his mutt…you see one you see the other jogging along." The head SES chap confided. "We're about to send a couple of dirt bike riders along that alternate track to cover our tracks though we're not confident of finding anything. There are little alternatives to investigate around this area and if we don't find his body then I reckon we're looking at a serious crime where his and mutt's bodies are buried somewhere out there well away from here. Being out here for the past couple of nights would not be comfortable especially for an older bloke with little meat on his bones."

I turned the information over in my mind. Turning to the head SES bloke I asked softly,

"The Deputy chief and his missus? A happy couple?"

"Hah! I've seen better. They're relationship can be a little toxic at times. Sudden uproars no matter where they are…and not good company after a couple of gins if you get my drift."

"The extended family?"

"It's a small community here where everyone knows everyone. The son-in-law some say took the NBN job to be away from the farm which is basically run by Missus Bartholamew and her caustic daughter Jedda…the old bloke comes up regular-like as the farm has been in his family for several generations…and that's when the shit usually hits the fan."

I nodded, turned around to survey the dense bush around us.

“You’ve been at it for what? Almost three days now. If he wanted to be found, don’t you think you’d have come across him and his dog by now?” Angie offered logically. I nodded as I began to walk towards our Unmarked. Angie quickly caught up with me.

“Where to Boss?” She asked as she turned the motor over, adjusting the temperature to warm. A stiff southerly had sprung up and I reckon it was straight off the high country or straight off the ocean.

“Winter is announcing its arrival.” I conceded. “It would be hell out here overnight…two nights if he and his mutt were out here which I doubt very much they both would survive. He has either encountered trouble or left without wanting to be located. He was a tall streak of skin and bone. A jogger of renown distance. With no meat on his skinny frame and little clothing…nah, he wouldn’t have survived the first night.” I clucked my tongue and slapped my thigh. “I wonder if he has a laptop back at his daughter’s joint.” I suddenly asked no-one. “C’mon, let’s go pay them a visit. It’s only a short drive from here so the SES boss informed me.”

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

I could almost hear our Unmarked complaining…it wasn’t meant to be on bumpy, dusty dirt roads. We came to a small fork in the bush road. One way led to a gate with a ‘trespassers keep out’ sigh hanging precariously off it while the other was a very wide cattle grid and impressive post and rail fencing on either side. A sign on the side fence nominated this as ‘Harry’s Rest.’

We drove slowly over the cattle grid as I heard a dog start barking.

“Their doorbell, I betcha.” I commented quietly to myself. “I betcha you could go to every farm in the land where it mattered nought if the farmhouse was at the gate or several kilometres away, they’d have a dog who started barking the moment you crossed their cattle grid…betcha.”

We rounded a bend to come out onto pastured land dotted with cattle grazing. One or two raised their heads to look at our passing. Uninterested so it seemed, they returned to their grazing. The dog continued to bark. Half a kilometre on we came to a typical Australiana farmhouse with tall chimneys and all. One set had smoke curling lazily from its stack. A woman stood slowly from a settee which was in deep shade under a wide veranda to stand

hanging onto a veranda post as though she was going to fall from the veranda at any moment. I calculated that she was tipsy…it could be gin, as the head SES bloke intimated.

The dog continued to bark.

I could see it now chained to a tree and within easy reach of a large dog kennel made out of a steel eighty-litre oil drum. Water, and food bowls both half full also within reach for the mutt. The dog did not seem that keen on its daily food allotment. My lot would have gulped down whatever was in front of them and begged for more the moment their bowls were licked spotlessly clean!

"Mmm…what type of dog did the acting deputy chief have? Someone mentioned the breed…one of the SES chaps while we were in their camp…"

Angie shook her head. She had not been near when the breed was offered during a quiet conversation between me and the SES Boss.

As I alighted from our Unmarked, the dog stopped barking and retreated sullenly into its kennel as though it was disappointed that it was us and not someone else. I scratched my head and smiled slightly as I walked towards the woman who had not moved as though the veranda post was a lifeline.

"City coppers. They rang to say you'd be coming…" A slight slur.

I nodded. Smiled up at her as I produced my ID Card from my inside pocket of my suit coat.

"They?" I questioned.

"The Cop Station at Hawks Nest. They rang to warn us." A titter at her comedic effort.

"I see…" I introduced myself and Angie who had come to stand beside me. At least she smiled as I was a picture of stone. There was something about the woman…

"You want to ask me questions about my husband Harry. He's gone and good riddance to him." A good start, I thought. "The older he got the more demanding he got…the grouchier he became. It was never a good time when we came up here for a break. We…or at least Harry owns this property. Used to be his family who bought it years ago before there was even a house in Hawks Nest…now look at it. We got joggers and walkers and bike riders doing their daily exercise along the walking trail. Harry cleaved it out of the bush well before I knowed him…Harry's Trail. Yer can't get away from it, can yer? If there's nothing else, I'll wish yer a good day."

She stood away from the veranda post, turned and began to walk unsteadily towards the front door.

“Arrh…Harry’s dog…”

She half-turned to look at me as she replied.

“Yeah…Mutt…what about it?” The dog stuck its head out of the kennel. Her tail wagging as her name was spoken.

“What type of dog was it?”

“Umm…the runt of the litter. A Labradoodle but it was on the small size. She and Harry were inseparable.”

I took a step closer to the dog kennel.

“Mutt!?” I yelled a little loudly to see the dog’s head emerge again from the kennel. “Inseparable you say…”

The woman turned to look at the dog then back at me. A slight nod.

“Yeah…” She grabbed the insect-screen door. “If there is nothing else…” The woman pushed open the door to disappear inside.

“Not exactly a useful conversation…I would want more. Do you want to follow her inside?”

“Mmmph…no. I reckon the dog will give us more answers.” I offered as I walked towards the kennel. The mutt came out to greet me tail wagging. Dogs know instinctively dog-loving people. I undid the chain to allow the dog to lead.

“What are you doing? Where are you going?” Angie asked, surprise in her voice. Regardless, she followed us like the loyal little lapdog that she is. We walked away from the house down the slope turning towards what was a Hay and Machinery Shed not in the same neat style as the house. It was just the typical shed made of a rough timber frame and galvanised sheeting on the roof and sides. The dog led us into the side that was the Machinery Shed, whimpering as it scratched the earth under a large Tractor before sitting on a mound of earth that had recently been turned.

“They could kill the old bloke, but the dog. Never!!Country people! That was asking too much of ‘em.” I exclaimed as I rang the Forensic Pathology and Forensic Trace people in Sydney. I

then rang the local people and the SES calling off the search for the Acting Deputy Commissioner Major Works, commanding that a local contingent stand around the recently dug grave for security purposes. The local coppers could do the arrest and charge of the old girl and her daughter for homicide murder of the old bloke.

I took Mutt…she seemed to hang off me…Tellie maybe a little miffed that I had purloined another dog…but…this one would wither and die without that close human connection. I just could not let that happen…dog-loving people…what the heck!

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

One of the hardest things to do was to pick up a Case left unattended for weeks to investigate an unexpected Case that has suddenly appeared, then convert back to the original Case.

"Okay Joe. Where we at with the Jenni Crowe Case? It's been a while so what do we do next?"

"Going back to see retired Detective Harry Newcombe. I have this feeling that he was not completely open with us when last we spoke…"

"You can remember that?" Angie cried, surprise in her voice. At times like this I truly wondered what she thought of me…a doddering old man I reckon!

"That's something you must remember Angie…you have to compartmentalise each Case as there will be times when you're juggling a few homicides at the same time…it will be hard at first, but it is something you must learn…" I commented as I knocked on Harry's front door again.

"Yer back again so soon. What did you forget?" Harry asked as he stood at his opened front door. He knew why we were back again. He shook his head and opened the door wide to allow our entry. We went straight into the Lounge Room and sat. There was no easy banter. No offer of coffee.

"You know." Is all I said.

He wiped his hand across his mouth and down the side of his jaw. Shook his head.

“I’ve kept quiet for all these years…it could put the spanner in the works for sure…um…my two daughters, they were sixteen and eighteen at the time of Crowe’s disappearance which was later transferred to the Murder Squad and my and Levi Sol’s desks. When girls are that age, they go a little silly…telling the world that their latest love is for life…usually being discarded like a pair of old, smelly socks within a week or three…um…Tracey was a bit like that…you could tell she was in love, but she failed to tell the world. That worried me…look…I could do with another coffee. I know I’ll not sleep well tonight, so what the heck. Joe, Angelica?”

He stood with a groan and without waiting for an answer disappeared into the Kitchen. I followed him out as I knew he was hurting having thought he and his partner Sol Levi were the cause of Tracey losing the job she loved. When he saw I was behind him, he walked to the end bench of the Kitchen blowing his nose and wiping at his eyes.

No ‘goolies’ hung off his eyelashes…

“Harry,” I offered gently as I placed my hand on his shoulder. “You didn’t get her fired. Sure, she showed promise as a Dee but what she did, she did knowing it was wrong which would have caused her heaps of trouble…which it did. For what it is worth, she has never been happier. Six kids and another on the way. She wants eight by the time she is forty which is looming closer…she’s as happy as a pig in shit…or a new Mum deep in baby poo, icky nappies and the smell of regurgitated mother’s milk…a smell that I think is gross. When did you tell the Boss?”

“Ooh…just before the Court Case commenced. All I know is that Sol and I were on a surveillance op up Grafton way…a week away from Sydney and our other Cases. When we returned to the Office the following week her desk had been cleaned out and she was gone. I remember when I told Denny Turner, her face went black, and I am sure I muttered something about ‘not shooting the messenger.’ That kind of broke the tightness of the situation…funny thing was, I got the impression she knew something was up but was waiting for some kind of confirmation from a third party…”

“Sol?”

“Yeah…could have been, I guess. He could read me pretty good…and he was as straight as an arrow so it could have been him following me and coming to the same conclusion with him confiding in the Boss well before I did…that’s just a guess on my part as I really don’t know…and with both Turner and Sol now dead, there’s no chance of confirming that as more than a guess.”

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

"Mister Douglas Faulkner?" I asked into the microphone that connected me to the bodiless person who answered the ring. The microphone and camera their link to the outside world. I hated those things as they could see us on a small television screen in the safety of their abode while we were left standing non-plussed as to who was spying on us!

"No…sorry. Doug's working…arrh…sorry. I copped a double shift and have just gone to bed. That's why I'm all fuzzy. I'm Doug's partner…by marriage. Sas Garcia. How can I help?"

He must have sensed by my pause that I was somewhat of a dinosaur in this age of enlightenment. I identified myself and my young partner Angie asking whether it was possible to interrupt the man at his employment. He adopted a more churlish tone after hearing my uncertainty. He would have experienced such a tone for most of his life so he should be used to it…or I should have moved on with the rest of the population and become more tolerant of these 'fringe' people in the population. We run across them frequently…I had no real excuse…

"Doug is the First Assistant to the Administrator of the large hospital three blocks over. I am a radiologist at the same hospital…that is where we met. I will ring Doug to let him know you're on your way."

Clunk…that was it!

"Mmm…well done Sherlock. You have just returned us cops to a more savage period in the Eighties when gay people were hunted down and tossed from high sea cliffs onto the rocks below!"

"What are you on about, young Watson?" I knew well enough what she was on about as I had been in the middle of those gay-hating deaths in the eastern suburbs as I was gainfully employed as an undercover cop whose area of influence was the entire Greater Sydney area.

"You made it obvious that you are a gay hater…"

"Be blowed! That is bullshit!!" I slumped down into the front passenger seat and buckled up as Angie turned the motor over of our Unmarked. "I do not think I've ever told this story to any of my Murder Squad partners that I've had for the past umpteen years. Never too sure if it is prudent option." I scratched my scalp and pulled at my earlobe. I was nervous and unsure whether I should relate my experiences of that time. What the heck, I'd held it close for many years. "By the late Eighties, my undercover partner Barry Holtz had long gone by a couple of years, and I was flying solo. Something I would never wish on my worst enemy…it was tippy-

toe stuff. I spent a lot of time in the Eastern Suburbs, and you soon picked up whispers and rumours about gay guys being bashed…with some dying from their wounds…" I shook my head and angrily wiped away that wayward tear.

"If you like we can try for another day…we turn right here, don't we? To head towards the hospital."

"Yeah…up to the lights that you can see at the top of the hill. Turn right there…no…it's okay but I was privileged…that maybe is the wrong word… to see extremely poor policing which got my nose out of joint. Being undercover I couldn't expose myself not even to suburban troops but because of this mayhem with no active police involvement, I was close…so close to calling it a day. I was ashamed to call myself a copper. The whole set-up pissed me off no end! These deaths may have been gay guys but none of them deserved to be tossed off a sea-cliff for a seventy-metre fall…and be forgotten about…ignored or 'serves themselves right' as that type of behaviour was not acceptable in twentieth century Sydney...fuck!" I grabbed the panic bar above the door frame. "I think there's a green arrow turn right here Angie…arrh…bugger off!" I fingered the driver who thought was his right to teach us about waiting for the green arrow. "Go right on the green arrow Ang…what I am about to confess I have never told another living soul. As an Undercover Cop out in the field you're on your own. Back then you can't waltz into a local cop station to say you have witnessed three homicides in the last week where two were thrown off the sea-cliff and the other bashed to death near Central Railway station…all by the same six guy gang…aided and abetted by some unscrupulous and don't care less attitude cops. With Aids scaring the bejesus out of everyone including the straight community where there were silly opinions floating around including you could get Aids by sitting on the same bus seat as an infected person, things got stupid…everyone was an expert. Those six guys? Four have life-long injuries that will remind them of every step they take, and one doesn't have a tooth of his own in his head…they never touched another gay guy or bullied anyone else that I know of…sweet revenge…turn left at that entrance there…the one that has a large 'Hospital Administration' sign this side of it…"

Angie did a tight turn into the Administration Building parking lot stopping at a boom gate. She slid her window down shouting into a 'voice box' to identify herself and the reason for the intrusion. The boom gate slowly raised, and we crawled into the small parking lot, picking a car space that signposted 'Official Vehicles Only.' She knew that I had not finished my admission and that once I begun, I had to finish the revelation.

"The leader of the gang had affiliations with several Bikie Gangs in the western suburbs and to give him a giant heave-ho was asking for trouble…or trying to construct a scene that would pass all examinations as a homicide is a hard thing to do, so I threw him over the same high cliff line where so many gays had met their early demise. Funny enough…or ironically, the morning papers labelled another gay guy had committed suicide the previous night by throwing himself off the same high cliff line those others had also done. This would have been a big no-no to the Bikie Gangs who dropped their links with the guy immediately the news

broke…I was in the clear as the local cops didn't break a sweat investigating this latest death…to them it was just another gay guy suicide case."

The Admin. building was an eight-floor square blob of tinted glass having skyway corridors from the first, second and third floors to the main hospital wing. The Administrator and his staff were on the top floor with his first and second Assistants and their staffs occupying the floor below. I have no idea who occupied the remaining floors. The ground floor was the reception and information area and a bustling café that would always be full to overflowing. We found a table and ordered coffees and a slice of orange and almond cake each. We guessed that Faulkner's partner would have rung him the moment we turned away from the premises. We decided we would let him sweat for a couple of minutes.

Once we started waiting for our snacks, I resumed the story.

"If you ask me do I feel any remorse, guilt, or contrition for what I did, the answer is a firm no. Do I feel satisfaction, vengeance or pride the answer is a firm no, but one thing that did come out of those brutal and savage times was a slow realisation amongst journalists mainly, of the terrible injustices that took place with the local cops found wanting. I think this may have involved firstly a book, then a series of television specials that pricked the consciousness of the public, politicians and honest cops coming up through the ranks. This has led quickly to all gay people having rights never dreamt of ten years previously."

Our orders came which we had in silence. When we finished, she sat back to ask what must have been on the tip of her tongue while we indulged our snacks.

"So, you think you helped the LGBTIQ movement with your undercover shenanigans?"

"Huh! I don't know and who cares? That was almost thirty-five years ago…you going to turn me in for first degree murder and other brutal bashings from back in those days?"

"What!! If I were in your shoes at that time and capable of hoeing into the scum of that period, I would have gladly done it and not felt any remorse. You'll never hear me repeat a word of your story to anyone…believe me." She looked intently at me nodding her head. I had no reason to suspect she would ever repeat the truth to anyone else.

I believed her as I had done with Marge Hendricks my first female partner…and one or two of my other partners…there had never been a whisper from any of them!

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

"Mister Faulkner?" As we were guided into his office suite located at the external corner of the building, I inquired about the views. The office offered a perspective of the bustling T-intersection framed by sizable drought-resistant gum trees.

"Douglas…or Doug which is my preference. How can I help you. My partner Sass rang to say that you two Detectives were looking for me…what is it you want of me?" He asked us to move away from his desk to a corner where chairs were arranged around a glass-topped coffee table. The ubiquitous reading material carefully stacked to one side. Never to be read but were purchased as a tax return. All were medically bent which meant normal people like us would never try to interpret them! Views out onto the busy arterial road through a floor to ceiling corner window which was a stone's throw away as we were cantilevered out nigh over the Council footpath. Not a sound of the traffic could be heard suggesting thickened or double glass panels. Spare no money on the administrative accommodation.

Doug cleared his throat. He shifted in his seat across from us, repeatedly adjusting his posture as if he were experiencing discomfort. I found the chairs very comfortable.

"Coffee for both of you?" He asked. We both declined stating we had just imbibed downstairs in the cafeteria.

"Not bad coffee…" Angie murmured to which the man agreed. This was a tactic to help the man settle. We'd had enough coffee for the morning. Turning it into somewhat of a joke to lighten the mood which was decidedly heavy. Doug was as nervous as a wild cat caught in a wire trap.

I glanced out of the corner window after settling into the comfortable visitor chair. Surveyed the room before I settled on Doug Faulkner.

"You seem a little nervous Mister Faulkner…" I observed, wanting him to confess and perhaps tell us why this was so…

"Hah! As a God-fearing, law-abiding citizen who is sitting opposite two Murder Squad Detectives, who wouldn't be…how can I help you. I know of no-one who has been killed recently in my sphere of responsibility…"

"Fifteen years ago. Jennifer Crowe." I suggested quietly wanting to observe his reaction. There was none! He now sat like a stone effigy as though the real world was far away.

“Arrh, yes. That far back.” He eventually offered. “I would imagine the killer is out of prison by now.” A little titter as though this was a light comic routine.

“Another eight months maximum if he continues to refuse to inform the Parole Board where he disposed of her body…he still adopts the cry that he did not kill Crowe, so he knows not where her body is located…he wishes to ignore the fact that forensic evidence at the trial was heavily against him…and still is…has actually increased…his constant cries of innocence becoming a burden to the Parole Board.”

“Mmm…convenient.”

“Some may say that. Yes.” I let time slip by. “The Fearsome Four…” I suggested to break the silence.

“Arrh, yes. We four used to rule the Primary School schoolyard…even through to High School.” A smile at the memories. “The four of you used to organise a fishing trip up or down the coast when Uni Classes and long weekends permitted…yeah…good times…right through Uni. I guess it only ended after Jenni went missing…I’ve never thought about it that way before.” He cocked his head in a questioning manner.

“The four of you were on a fishing trip that weekend that she did go missing. Where were you?”

“Oh gee…a guess. Down the South Coast…Merimbula or Eden I would imagine. We tried to placate my complaints as I had to travel from Canberra. The other three had it easier from Sydney. If we decided on the north coast, it was a pain in the arse for me…”

“So, if you were in Eden for example, it would have been almost impossible to drive up to Sydney then return without one of the other three noticing your absence…highly improbable.”

There was silence for what seemed like minutes.

“Doug…” I encouraged softly.

“What’s going on here?” Faulkner belligerently addressed me, sitting up straight in his chair. “Are you suggesting that I may have killed Jenni? Wrong. Totally wrong. Like all of us, I loved the girl in my own way.”

“What way was that sir?”

“I think that’s enough Detectives. You should leave!” He stood in anger to show us the door.

“Hmm…interesting…” I thought. “Emotions still raw after so many years. Why? A guilty conscience perhaps…”

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

“Archie Cusack. He’s working around here close, so we believe…on the hospital extensions and renovations. Let’s see what he has to say about our intrusion.” I coughed. “Known to the other three as ‘Sharky’ Cusack as he was the only one out of the four of them able to catch sharks…all the time apparently, so says the records.” I turned to my young partner. “Do you remember reading that?”

She shrugged, not remembering the point.

“Aren’t sharks a protected species?” Angie asked as she slowly drove around to the construction site entry point.

“Yeah…they are now but I don’t know about in those days…there’s the main entrance gate…drive through.”

We were waved down to stop beside a bloke with a ‘stop sign.’ He looked important.

“That’s as far as you’re going people!” He instructed. “Reverse back and get the hell out of here.” He bent down to look at our ID Cards. “I don’t care if you’re the King and his consort, reverse back and get the hell out of here…yer holding up traffic and yer don’t have the correct authorisation to enter this site so piss off!” I glanced to our rear seeing nothing behind us. This could develop into a nasty event…I’d heard of Building Sites being closed down…black banned because a couple of coppers would not take no for an answer when they were looking for a couple of drug dealers who they knew were on-site…things could escalate quickly.

He seemed to take pride in telling us where to go.

Like a marauding swarm of Killer Bees, we were suddenly surrounded by the angry faces of workers and unionists all chanting oft-heard slogans. “Protect the rights of the workers” and other inane sayings heard a thousand times before. They slapped and thumped our Unmarked panels. Rocking it side to side with the real threat it could be overturned. I glanced across at Angie who had a frightened look on her face. I guess it could have been the first time that she had faced such concentrated rage…the rabble appeared to drift away as quickly as they had emerged. A figure of authority stood in front of the Unmarked gesturing for us to slowly

follow him. We did as instructed, following him slowly; parking under the elevated site cabins that also hung over the Council footpath. After introductions we followed him up two sets of stairs to a second storey row of site cabins.

Archie Cusack shook our hands formally after offering us a choice of drinks. We all accepted coffee which we were told with a grin and a wink was from a De Longo Coffee machine.

"A relative?" He asked Angie as he turned to her. "You sure ruffled Doug Faulkner's feathers. Yes, he has already contacted me, and I will lay a bet and predict that he is talking to Al 'Bertie' Springstone about your visit and your reasons at this moment…what are your reasons, by the way?" He turned sideways as the coffee mugs were offered to us. "Arrh…thanks Hussain. You saw how quickly the union brigade are in taking over a situation to better their cause. Politics! It's always the same with them whether they are right or wrong they are always right…Jenni Crowe. You are re-investigating her death." He stated matter-of-factly as he nodded at us.

"No…no. You have got it all wrong. The guilty person is still in prison soon to be released without ever revealing where he hid the body those fourteen years ago. We are searching for her remains."

"Oh! Isn't there a Law that forces the guilty party to reveal that fact?" Archie Cusack asked, rubbing his nose.

"If the guilty party fails to provide that information, the parole period can be held back or be overridden. Withdrawn by the Court. He can lose the lot which can be several years added onto his sentence time. Sometimes it's a carrot that works…in this case it appears to have failed. His cries of innocence throughout his sentence means he cannot reveal that fact because he did not kill and dispose of Crowe's body…that is his strategy though it is working against him…he should employ another Solicitor…"

"An ample excuse if you don't look at all the facts, I suppose." Cusack muttered in response.

"Back at the time of the crime, the forensic trace in the form of DNA was not as strong as it is to-day. Further analysis on vital parts has only reinforced the guilt of the prisoner." I took a sip of my coffee and stretched my legs under the table. This was obviously the Meal Room of the 'Tie Brigade' as the workers and unionists had tagged the Project Manager and his menagerie. "No…" I continued as I placed the mug on a coaster. "We are solely interested in trying to locate the poor woman's remains…thus the questions of you four firstly as you seem to have known her more than anyone else."

Cusack was an acute listener having an intelligent probing mind. We ran through the same addresses as we had with the first two with the only point that caused him discomfort was the

question about where the foursome was on that weekend that Jennifer Crowe disappeared. I skipped over this pretending to ignore it with Angie glancing worriedly in my direction.

"You were known as 'Sharkey' Cusack back in those days…"

"Hah! Yes…that was all I could catch. Nothing else…the others used to rib me about it…" He shook his head. Laughed at the memory.

We remained in the converted shipping container come meal room for close on two hours listening to similar responses to our questions as both Geof Crowe and Doug Faulkner had supplied. We left as the afternoon shift 'change-over' occurred.

"It's okay for the workers to get a break when such an operation as a continuous concrete pour is in progress, but I'm expected…and my Office boys are expected to be here on site until such time as the pour is finished…I'd say around ten to-night. A good pay drop for the lads…nothing extra for us poor administrators! Them's the breaks, eh? They would say that we earned a darn sight more than them, but we hold all the pay details…you would be shocked at what those blokes took home."

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

I glanced at my watch as I settled into the front passenger seat of our unmarked. Angie turned to me as she turned over the motor and clicked on the air-conditioning.

"Joe? What are we doing here? Are we investigating the Case again looking for a new suspect or are we trying to find the last resting place of Jenni Crowe?"

"You ever notice that when men discuss their pay packet, they're very reticent about how much they earn…more so than women. And when comparing their salary with other workers, they always indicate that they earn less than their co-worker. Which reminds me, I need to contact our Union Rep on our pay remuneration upgrade…we're way behind the pack! Again!" I turned to her and sighed. "Levi Sol and Harry Newcombe had a narrow field of investigation…who killed Jennifer Crowe. That's it! Nothing more. That's all they wanted to know. They were not derelict in their duty or in their investigation. They were not interested in Missing Persons who could have helped them…they were relying solely on forensic evidence which they thought would be sufficient to nail Perry Matthews after they exhausted examinations of the two other suspects. What are we doing here? To answer your question, trying to find Missus Jennifer Crowe's body. If that involves the spreading of the investigation

to other persons who might…might be helpful to our cause, then why not follow those examination avenues to see where they lead?"

I turned away as she started up the Unmarked. I could see her thinking over my words, nodding her head as she did so though she never reacted to this digression. I wondered if she figured it as a misdirection or just how my mind worked often in riddles.

Angie tried to ease the Unmarked out into the flow of traffic that was thickening up due to knock-off time for most. She was failing.

"Yeah…okay Joe…but I'll ask again…what are we doing with this Case?"

"Mmm…" I looked across at her as I did up my seatbelt. "Both!" I replied succinctly, gesturing with a finger to get going. "You have read both the Investigating Officers notes and the Court Files on this Case. One thing the three of them…and I bet when I 'conference call' Al Springstone in Melbourne that he confirms what the other three have already told us…that the last time all four were on a fishing trip was that weekend when Jenni Crowe disappeared. They are all confident that they spent that weekend in Eden. Too far to drive up to Sydney and back after doing the dirty deed…"

"Yeah…and?"

"They are protecting one another as I'll bet that last weekend was spent in Kiama…a sixty-kilometre easy drive to Sydney and back."

"C'mon Joe…that is clutching at straws as there is nothing to prove that point…and so what? I was not aware we were re-investigating the Case for a new guilty person who murdered Jennifer Crowe…there is not one, Joe."

"No? I'll also say none of the four have discussed that point with one another but as good mates for so many years they did not need to. Each one of them knew they had good reasons to kill Jennifer Crowe…three of them to make amends to their mate and to protect their guilty mate and Crowezee to kill his wife for her philandering…they are protecting one another!" I harrumphed, pleased with my conclusion…until Angie asked that important question.

"Then which one did the dirty deed?"

"I have no idea…one of them or the four in cahoots…that's about as far as I can take it."

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

We spent the weekend in Newcastle attending the State funeral of the Acting Deputy Commissioner Major Works. I was surprised to see George Lees, the son-in-law of the Deputy Commissioner in attendance. Further surprised to see his tears at various times during the service.

I guess he had been close to his father-in-law, much more than even his own father. He relayed to me after the service and as we were sharing coffees and bikkies care of the NSW Police Force that while he liked and respected the man, his wife and mother-in-law were not warm favourites…never had been. He was forced to marry his wife even though she had lost the baby during the third trimester. He loved the life on the farm but chose to take on a job with the NBN Co. as that led to times away from the wife. His mother and father-in-law would be frequent visitors as the Deputy Commissioner loved the country life…this did not ease the air of discomfort whenever the older two were visiting…and since his wife and mother-in-law had been confined to the property by a Court Order he was forced to live with his parents…something that was quite agreeable to him.

It would be six months before the Preliminary Hearing was conducted. Transferred from Raymond Terrace to the Newcastle Criminal Court because of the importance of the Deceased. By that stage both women would not meet bail and would be placed on remand at the Women's Remand Centre at Raymond Terrace.

By that stage, George Lees had begged his parents to come share the farmhouse with him. His explanation was it was too big for one person to live in and within six months he had met up with a former school friend who, with her two kids had moved in as well! They had not been schoolyard lovers but more 'he's/she's cute' in schoolyard whispers.

It was by accident they met up again and let's just say the relationship was made to last!

It would be another two years before we would meet up with the extended family again at the time of the Trial in Newcastle. It was good to see the extended family and their endeavour to make a go of it in life…around that farm called Harry's Rest, a stone's throw from Hawks Nest. Their main source of income was the agistment of cattle for fattening up before auction and a similar number of sheep for mutton sales.

George Lees had left the NBN Co. concentrating his energy on making a go of the farm. It appeared they were winning as there were now six persons relying on the trade from the farm and they were living comfortably by all accounts.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

"Joe? You seem to have an itch that you can't scratch…you're travelling down a well-trodden road that has been historically well-walked before…by the two excellent, original Murder Dees who exhausted the subject…you only have to read their Murder Notes and their interpretation as they typed them up for the Murder Book. They interviewed the four separately at least four times and from memory they interviewed the four together several times. So did the DPP Investigators and the four mates were given the twice over by the Defence and Prosecution teams during Trial. All of us thought it was a 'laydown mezzair' that at some stage Jennifer Crowe's husband had done the deed…that's the usual in Cases like this…but husband Crowe could not be faulted…your application to travel to Melbourne to interview Albert Springstone is denied…and so is your want to engage in a conference call with the man. My interpretation on why you were requested to look at the Case again was to see if you could fathom where the woman's body maybe located. Not to go over old ground! Hear me!? Do not waste my time!!" She roared in an octave or two higher than her talking voice.

I tried to slam the Boss's door closed but being on an automatic door closer, it closed softly of its own accord!

My exit however from the boss's office was noticed by all those on the Squad floor as the roar of her voice three octaves higher than her normal speech pattern reverberated around the large space. Some of my colleagues looked up; others buried their heads in whatever they were doing at the time. No-one wanted to know or be involved. If I was being slammed by the Boss that morning, all would be aware that it was going to be a rough day with the Boss on the warpath for no other reason than to be irritable!

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

"What are you doing here young lady?"

"I am your partner. Where you go, I go." She succinctly replied.

"Very commendable young lady, but it could land you in strife with the hierarchy. Leaving your desk unattended without prior approval…" I commented as I side-glanced at my young partner.

“Where are you going apart from leaving your desk without approval?” Angie cheekily replied.

“That bloody desk owes me a couple of months …at least…the Boss knows that, but I think you could be in a different ballgame if you get my drift.” We both entered the elevator, carefully navigating the limited space as it was nearly full. We did not say a word until we stepped out onto the Ground Floor Lobby. Me still boiling over with anger. I was not used to be given the ‘old one-two-three’ by anyone not the least a female Boss…especially one who had little experience in dead bodies and homicide deaths!

“No car.” I instructed. “I reckon I could drive it over The Gap the way I feel at the moment…a coffee at an obscure coffee café.” I suggested. “There is a small café located not far from this place that I frequented for privacy reasons during my tenure with the AFP years ago. It also served good coffee. About four blocks from Police HQ and down at the rear of a basement walkway…let’s see if it is still in business, eh?”

I seemed to walk in circles with my mind blank on its location what with all the demolition and construction of this second CBD going on. I almost tripped over the basement walkway which was now a second entry point to the Parramatta Train Station and the soon to be completed underground rail line into the city. The small café was no longer at the end of everything as hundreds of people passed by every couple of minutes. Hurrying from or to creating a maze of note. Once the new Metro rail link was completed the café would lose its anonymous character. Still, we pluckily entered the café to take a table and two chairs towards the rear of the establishment. I noticed we were the only customers which to me was a bad sign. Sat in silent until a young lady came to serve us. My temperature again began to rise as there was no other customers but us…so why the total lack of instant service!?

“What now?” Angie asked after our wishes were dutifully taken. No smile or how’s the weather outside, just a courtesy non-attachment.

“The coffee used to be good…”

“How long ago was that?” Angie asked. “Bet the place has gone through a million owners since then….”

“What pisses me off the most is her want to tell me how to run an investigation.” As though Angie’s last comment had not been heard. “I’ll lay odds she has never looked at a homicide body let alone investigate it…I’ve been at it for over forty years which must stand for something. Time to think about retirement I reckon…yeah…time soon to walk away though I would like to end on a successful note; wouldn’t you?”

“C’mon Joe. Stop freaking me out with such nonsense. You’re not ready to retire for a couple more years, aren’t you? We’ll knock over this case and the next couple to come along, don’t you think?”

“Mmm? Maybe…in which case what way should we proceed with this Case. Looking for Jennifer Crowe’s body seems as far away as it was when we began to look though all the historical paperwork…” Our orders came. I nodded my thanks to the surly young waitress. I figured she really did not want to be here. “Mmm…yeah…still the same coffee beans as I remember from ages ago.” I commented as I took the first tentative sip.

“Crowe’s confidantes…” Angie muttered as she cut into her marble cake with cream.

“Mmm…yeah. Good suggestion…” I mumbled as I hoed into a very moist orange cake with shaved almonds and cream. “Yeah…a list of our known young men who were called up before the Court. There were fifteen…or was it twenty from memory with only eight called to give evidence…why?”

“Repetition of evidence perhaps…” Angie offered. I nodded as I licked errant cream from the corner of my mouth. It made sense to me. I pushed the small plate away having left nothing but a couple of crumbs and a smearing of cream.

“You know that Excel thing that you can do on the computer…I learnt about the application years ago but have forgotten more about it than I now remember…can you do it?”

“Excel? Yeah…easy as.” Said like a patronising computer nerd. “You want that list of the fifteen blokes set up in Excel. Alphabetically constructed with…say their date of birth; how old they were when Jennifer Crowe was reported missing; how long their dalliance was with the woman in weeks; their current addresses which would be easy to get with their addresses when Jennifer Crowe went missing which would be just as easy if they had drivers’ licences at the time of her disappearance…what was that date?”

“Arrh…” I was lost in the sudden explosion of information. “Arrh…twenty-sixth January twenty-ten.” Reading the date off my smartphone. “That was the date she was reported missing by her husband, but it was some weeks before a homicide Case was launched…around the middle of February that year with those two-gun Dees Harry Newcombe and Levi Sol who both saw it as their swansong taking charge of the investigation. Doing as good a job or better than you and me could ever do!”

“Joe? They were looking for a murderer. We are looking for the Victim’s body. You seem to mix the two up all the time…we are looking for a body!” She repeated.

CHAPTER THIRTY

I sheepishly crept to my desk earlier than normal hoping to catch the boss before other Dees began to fill the Squad Floor. That wasn't to be as the boss was not warming her seat…and was missing for the rest of the week. In Melbourne for an interstate cop conference were the whispers. That put the kibosh on any apology I wanted to pass on to her. The matter would be forgotten by next week when she was due to return to her office.

There were two, two-man teams from the dogwatch night shift still at their desks pounding away on their laptops. Probably finishing up a case or two to pass onto the DPP for completion. A good feeling. They would be too engrossed for a natter so I continued to slump at my desk wondering whether I should join the chlorinated people in the sub-basement gym for a lap or two of the pool. The thought did not excite me. Instead, I slid the top Murder Book off the pile from the file cart at the side of my desk. Began to read it again…the initial investigation of the Jennifer Crowe disappearance come Murder Case. There had been a lapse of several weeks before her disappearance was reported to when it was picked up as a probable murder case. Had there been anything…anything at all of significance during that hiatus that would cause the investigation to advance?

I sat up and addressed my laptop. Punching in my query of events linked back to the Crowe Disappearance.

Nothing much at all…not even a DV Case to report on. A Missing Persons' Report was submitted for a Mister Allan Price. Reported missing three days after the Crowe disappearance report was submitted. I printed out Allan Price's report to attach to the Crowe Murder File.

Interesting. Why? I had no idea, but it made the hairs on the back of my neck stand erect. It shouldn't have mattered as there are usually ten missing persons submitted each week…Price just a number…one of many…but he lived in proximity to the Crowe family home back in the day…same suburb…the lad was twenty-one years of age at the time of his disappearance. One year to go at Sydney University on an Architectural Degree. A dux student. A handy cricketer. A flop at any League or Union game. An above average Chess player. No attachments. Lived with a sister and another brother in the family home. Both parents deceased.

A synapsis sparked then died at this find…a connection? But I did not know at this stage what that connection was…apart from locality…

I tapped again…a Mister Vlad Sumner reported missing around the same fifteen-day period between the woman going missing to when it was turned over to the Murder Squad. Similar

age. Lived in the same neighbourhood as the Crowes. Studying his Real Estate Degree at the local Tech College…again the hairs on the back of my neck rose. Lived in a joint Uni student 'bug' house with a fluid number of other students and young people. The address a Number One street on the Drummoyne Headland. The house would be well over the two-mil mark today, I surmised.

I printed out the report and anything else I could find on the lad and attached it to our new file on the whereabouts of Jennifer Crowe's body.

A detail of delighted detectives ambled onto the Squad Room floor. The nightshift guys long gone. I had not noticed their exit. A cloud of chlorine wafted around this new rabble as though the smelly gas lifted spirits and caused elation amongst those who imbibe. Their hair still damp. Their faces having a certain glow that only chlorinated water can give.

Angie broke from the rabble to place a large coffee container on my desk.

"Knew you'd be here." She delightfully boasted, as though this would be her high point in what could be a boring day.

"Ta! Needed that…." I watched her as she slumped into her chair to swivel it around to face me. "That list…chart…" I began. "You know that spreadsheet I asked you to begin…can you add a couple more names to it?" I enquired not too sure on the answer.

"Excel." Angie added as though she was a computer geek of note to my complete ignorance of running anything computer-ish!

"Yeah, that. How have you been going with it?"

"Yeah…easy as to add a couple more names or any number you like. I have identified the fifteen names. Seven of which were not called to give evidence at Trial. Most I have completed including what type of vehicle if any, they may have owned at the time of Crowe's disappearance and probable murder. Three names I have not been able to advance…one Allan Price, Vlad Sumner, and Andes 'Andy' Seppi…I do not know where they are."

I fluttered my hands at her.

"Those two names…how come you've included them? I only found out their connection when they were reported missing within that period between Crowe's disappearance to when she was listed on the Murder Squad homicide list…"

"Yeah…I guess I was a day ahead of you. They were listed because they appeared in a search of missing persons between Crowe's disappearance and her possible homicide listing that I

undertook the other day. I'm about fifty percent complete on the chart. That 'fancy car'? If we could nail that then we would be halfway there to identifying that address where Crowe was buried. If it is all true what the original Dees suspected." Angie concluded.

"The trouble is we could already have the name…with his vehicle noted. The fancy car might belong to his father or brother, borrowed to impress his secret love…or borrowed as a chick magnet which was common in those days."

"I doubt our Jennifer Crowe would have been impressed with such material things." Angie added scornfully.

"Hmm…yeah, you could be right. Very good work on this." I uttered, tapping the chart. "Um…can you leave off that for a bit. I want a search done on any male who has gone missing in the year 2010. Confine your search to include the dates from 26/01/2010 to 23/02/2010. Male aged between eighteen to twenty-four. Try single first then try married if nothing comes up on the first swoop…must live in proximity to Crowe's address at that time."

Angie was furiously writing down the search criteria. By the expression on her face, she felt she had already completed that search as part of her overall construction of the Excel spreadsheet, but she would always make allowances for my forgetfulness.

"One thing…" She interrupted. "The original fifteen? Now seventeen. Out of that number at least two…perhaps four of them would not like being dropped…they'd be as mad as cut snakes…possibly…more than likely more attuned to being the offender…and if still alive would be known to the local coppers on DV events…and another thing. If it were true that Jennifer Crowe had that fuller date book, she'd have to have the weekly dateline written down in a diary…you know…what day and time and where the meeting was taking place…and who with. If she had a full calendar with different guys every day, then she'd need that type of calendar…well I would otherwise I'd get totally confused and I doubt our Missus Crowe would be any different."

"Arrh…good point. Have you isolated any names that could/may fit into that category and no…the diary is in with her other stuff in an evidence box. Nothing in her Diary like that."

"Maybe a laptop…" She was running out of alternatives. "If I knew her password, then I could get into her cloud account…was the cloud around in two thousand and ten?"

I shrugged. I did not have a clue what she was on about!

"Give it a shot in any case…those additional things will keep you busy for a while I reckon." I was guessing…

"…and while I am busy on all that work you have saddled me with, what will you be doing?" Angie confronted me pouting her lips as a spoilt child may do.

"Um…firstly…it's my shout for the coffee…and then I will be re-reading Levi Sol and Harry Newcombe's informal notes against what they printed up in the Murder Book…looking again for any discrepancies. Okay, young lady?"

She did not reply but instead buried herself behind her computer screen.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

"Mmm…it is coming back to me. Easy when you know how."

"What's that, Joe?"

"This Excel thing. This chart whatsamajig. I will see if I can fill out your blanks…Roads and Maritime Services should have records going back passed that date…"

I did not see Angie's smirk as she ducked her head behind her laptop screen. She had been through those records twice to obtain the necessary information on vehicle ownership and registration certificates for confirmation on names, DoB's, and addresses. Current and those going back fifteen years.

We hardly spoke a word to each other for the next four days to the end of the week except to negotiate who is shouting for coffee next and the occasional back break that I needed when my back began to object to its lengthened seated position.

"Enough is enough!" I murmured more to myself. I leaned back in my chair, then stood and ambled around the Squad floor occasionally arching, bending, twisting, and rotating my back to ease its constant objection! I circled back to my desk suggesting it was Angie's turn to shout. It was mid-afternoon on the Friday, and we had barely said a word to each other. A toot break, a negotiated coffee purchase or a back 'break' was our regime for those days until we agreed that no further data could be extracted from our and other data banks. We would have achieved our goal which would mean we would sit and discuss together what relevant information we had extracted…

"I'm coffee-ed out, so a chilled bottle of water please." I ordered much to Angie's annoyance. "Whatever for yourself." I handed her a ten dollar note. That immediately improved things.

She grabbed at the ten-dollar-note that I held out to her, jumping from behind her desk to head for the Lift Lobby. It was obvious she also needed a break…

As she returned to place the chilled bottle of water onto my desk which instantly made a ring of condensation marking the middle of my desktop which angered me, she had a worried look on her face.

"You know? I been thinking…" She began.

"I do not doubt that! It took you double the normal time to exercise the order…you had time to think about the world and all its problems. You had problems with the order, eh? Forget the order, huh?" I insinuated.

"No…no. Half the building was down there getting their afternoon fix of caffeine readying themselves for the afternoon train ride home…"

"Mmm…no Friday afternoon drinkies at the nearest pub, eh…yeah. What were you thinking about?" Prodding her memory banks as I unscrewed the bottle cap and took a large gulp of water. It went down well…

"Um…I've just about completed the Excel broadsheet with only three squares to fill in…and four names that stop around the time of Crowe's reported disappearance…four names that I cannot progress…"

"Who reported her missing?" I asked sure the question had been asked before.

"Her husband on the Australia Day Long weekend in 2010". Angie replied without skipping a beat as though the information was in the forefront of her mind.

"He must have known of his wife's peccadilloes…she was busy every week. She did not work!?" I could not get my mind around the fact that he did not know…for four years she continued the habit…no sexual advances except we thought for the favoured two though there were chaps biting at the bit.

"She was working throughout their pre-marital period and for about a year after they married. There was misconduct resulting in her being asked to leave the establishment that she had been at for close on five years. Further details are currently unavailable. The reactions by Geoffry Crowe when the number of young bucks interested in his missus came out in Court blindsided him. The first time it was mentioned put him into hospital…but you still like him as a suspect?" Angie asked as she picked up her bottle of iced tea looking over the top of the rim as she took a decent gulp.

"I…I can't get past him as a suspect…you know…always have the hubby as Suspect Number One until facts exonerate the guy."

"But he was cleared well before the Court Case began…"

"Was he? An alibi that his three mates swear on their mothers' graves was factual…Nah, not good enough for me…it would be easy for any one of them to cover for the other three…or vicy-versa." I scratched my scalp. "Those four missing dudes that you cannot progress. Who reported them missing?"

"Joe? Look…I have four names who were on Jennifer Crowe's dating list where everything about them stopped around the time of her disappearance…too much of a coincidence for me. I would like to investigate them further and secondly…" It was as if she had not heard my question about the four. She peered at her computer screen. "There are two names that are on Crowe's date list with both known *currently* by the local coppers for domestic violence offences. One of those named is onto his second marriage…that makes my nose itch. I would like to explore their lives more fully…"

"Mmm…we can manage the four of them together. Excellent work, Ang…well done. Let's take the obvious first…the guy in his second marriage and known to the local coppers for domestic violence infringements. Seems he could have a short fuse…and he is one of only seventeen persons who lived in proximity to her address. I guess I should ask whether he still lives locally to Crowe's district?"

"Yeah…he is a Real Estate Businessman with the practise in the local Balmain shopping mall. Verge Burram…does the name ring any bells?"

I shook my head. Names were becoming mired in this Case what with original dating partners, the 'Fearsome Four' whom I still had suspicions about, and every family member involved. I now kept a small notebook merely for names associated with a particular Case. Once upon a time I never needed such a mind jogging notebook but now…

Such a list also existed at the front of the first Murder Book volume which meant it also existed on both my iPad and smartphone…but I felt more comfortable with the written word and the feel of paper. I have no idea what that means except to say I am reverting to old habits…at this rate I will be back to longhand having done away with everything digital by the time I retire!

A fearsome day.

I wondered not for the first time whether other Dees went through the same process of ditching the digital for the feel of paper and longhand exercises. I was one of those chaps who could not understand or write shorthand…second languages did not come easy to me…

The question of who it was who reported the four guys missing disappeared into the fog of information that we were checking over and amassing…soon forgotten.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

Both Sam and Al were excited to see Sophie. They could not understand why there had been such a hiatus in my and Sophs relationship…then again, neither could I!

We watched as Sophie slowly walked along a given path in the Rehab Ward. She required a walking frame, a hoist to support most of her weight, assistance from two physiotherapists, and considerable effort to progress gradually. She was experiencing pain based on her facial expression. When she saw my two daughters, she began to cry…enough to make her lose her concentration on trying to walk. It looked as though it would be a long, slow, and painful rehabilitation.

Sophie allowed the hoist to take all her weight as she held out her right arm for my two to run to her…the three of them crying as only females can…Angie allowed some time for them to be re-acquainted before walking to her friend to join in the bawl session.

It seemed too short a period before one of the Physios asked us to leave…Sophie had had enough for the day.

As we sat in the Unmarked with Angie heading towards my place, Sam asked whether Sophs would ever be able to walk properly again.

“I don’t know, sweetheart. The Doctors are unsure themselves but knowing Sophie, she will give it one almighty try…she won’t give up easily…” This caused my two to again erupt into tears…life can be cruel.

I heard Angie sniffle and imagined her swiping her nose with the end of her coat sleeve…she’s a country girl after all. She glanced across at me.

“Do you think Sophs will keep her job?”

"Arrh…In the Highway Patrol Pursuit Unit? No…I really cannot see it. That leg is going to give her trouble for the rest of her life…sure, she can drive a car…an automatic but with her left shoulder as it is, that will be a grind for her…"

"What about…you know…where you were the Boss for a while. The Police Intelligence Unit…"

"Mmm…if there was to be a vacancy soon that coincides with her ready to take on a job, maybe…but otherwise there's no chance. The Unit was established with a maximum of twelve members, a Clerk, and an Oversighting Boss. That was it. No more. I have no idea why…perhaps for financial reasons…" I shrugged. "I really don't know…"

"Mmm…she perhaps could be shoved out of the Force on medical grounds if a spot isn't allocated for her…"

"Yeah…which would be a shame. There is a small Unit that deals with these problems or similar. Trying to find a spot inside or outside the Force…it is a little early worrying about these things as there is a fair way to go before she is physically and mentally ready to take on further responsibility…"

"Cross fingers."

"Yeah…cross fingers."

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

He was nervous as he examined our ID Cards carefully. He wiped both hands down the sides of his pants before sitting behind his desk and inviting us to sit before him. A man in charge of manipulating wants in the type of house home-seekers desired. A slick, late thirty-something-year-old with a practised smile and easy manner. A man for all seasons for whom I had an instant dislike. But then, Real Estate Agents were not my favourite species…they were well down the list!

“Don’t tell me the Ex is stirring up trouble again, eh?” The joke fell flat. This guy was used to being the centre of attention, able to tell jokes at the drop of a hat. Unfortunately, we were not clients looking for that desirable house who would appreciate his style of humour…

“Missus Jennifer Crowe.” I responded flatly looking coldly at the man.

“Ooh! Um…yes.” He sat up straight in his executive leather chair. “Now that brings back memories. Fifteen…sixteen years ago…a little longer for me. It is a little late in the day to be discussing the poor woman. Her killer would be out by now.”

“No…later this year…the middle of winter. We would like to locate her body before that date and were hoping you would be able to help us.”

“Me!? Yer got Buckley’s getting information like that outa me…I do not have a clue where she is! Never knew…”

Not the response I was looking for or expecting…it made me trip up on my questions. Angie picked up the tempo without missing a beat.

“You joined your father’s business straight from school…” More a statement than a question. Angie stated already knowing the answer. The slick man gave Angie the once over convincing himself he had little chance with her…

“Arrh, no…” The change of direction confused him as it was meant to. He bowed his head and ran his fingers through his hair. “It was always Dad’s wish that I would join the business straight from school. Caused a bit of a fuss when I opted for a gap year doing the south-east Asian backpackers tour up through Cambodia, Vietnam, Korea and up to Japan. Maybe that is why Dad hired Zed Cameron straight from school. We were good mates right through High School…maybe that was why he offered Zed a job…Zed was hanging out wanting to earn serious dosh…”

“Zed…” Angie enquired. A name she was familiar with who lacked detail on her excellent Excel chart. One of those names that still had to be investigated. His existence suddenly stopped around the time of Crowe’s disappearance…a little suspicious for both of us but we could not successfully progress his story no matter how hard we tried.

“Yeah…Zed Cameron…zedcam1992@bigpond.com…a cool email tag, eh?”

“Did he know Jennifer Crowe?” Angie’s heart must have skipped a beat as Zed’s name was down as being one of Crowe’s ‘dates’ but he disappeared around the time of Crowe’s disappearance. She glanced at me…she could smell new information about to emerge.

“Yeah…he was one of two that we knew of who was having sex with Crowe. After he told me that, I thought I was miles off the mark. Had no chance with her. I broke off with her as I was missing out…the other guy…I cannot remember…it was a foreign name.”

“Andos ‘Andy’ Seppi…Italian or Macedonian.” Angie offered.

“Yeah…could have been…I don’t remember.”

“You broke off with her…” Angie encouraged.

“Yeah…Zed was the charmer…I could not compete with him. Throughout school, Zed always got the girls, leaving me with the leftovers.”

“What happened to Zed?” Angie continued as though this was purely a conversational thing.

He shrugged, bit his bottom lip.

“We were going great guns. When I came back from my gap year, Dad automatically put me on the books. As far as I knew Zed was still seeing that Crowe woman. We both began the Real Estate Course together with plans to commence our own business without Dad’s help…but Zed just disappeared…I always thought he and Jennifer Crowe ran off together…until a couple of Detectives came around asking questions about her disappearance then I started to worry about Zed…but he was a bit like that. Would take off at the drop of a hat for a weekend which was our busiest trading time…annoyed me a bit. He lacked that air of responsibility, you know?”

“When was this?”

“Um…oh, around maybe twelve months after I returned…yeah…six months maybe. I’m not sure as it has been a while…”

“Your father…”

“Yeah…one of life’s cruel jokes…yeah…he was retiring that year. Two thousand and ten. Had gone down to the southern highlands to collect the keys and finalise the property settlement. Was going to leave the business in Zed and my names. An old historic house on about twenty acres beautifully restored a decade ago. He and his missus loved it…so did me and the wife…the first wife. She wanted it as part of the divorce settlement. Little chance of that. They say Dad had a medical episode. Doing his usual 140 up the Motorway. Ended up under one of those double semi-trailers. Burst into flames. Nothing left of them. The bloody car was a write-off…a bloody beaut car…melted…”

“Oh, I’m sorry for you. It must have been a horrible time for you…what kind of car was it?” Angie added getting to the crux of the matter.

“A classic. A 2006 X150 4.2 Jag convertible. He bought it new off the showroom floor. Only four in Australia at the time…a real classic.”

“You would have loved driving it around if you were permitted?”

“Yeah…took a while. But Zed and I thought we were the ant’s pants…a real chic magnet driving around the burbs in the thing.”

“We have a witness who saw a dark plum coloured convertible roar up the street, turn into the driveway and park under a carport as though the guy owned the joint. The driver alighted and bounced up onto the front covered veranda to open the front door with a key and step across the threshold as though he owned the place…ring any bells?” Angie pressed.

Verge Burram pushed away from his desk and twisted in his chair.

“You…” He shook his head. Squeezed his nose as he looked down at his shoes. “This happened what? Fifteen years ago!! Do you realise how many houses I enter each year. Ones owned by the firm…on our books and the ones we place on our advertising coupons and newspapers…have you any idea. I could not identify a house from fifteen years ago if I tried…jeezus! Um…if there is nothing else, I doubt you could ask any more such ridiculous questions. If you can see yourselves out, thank you for your time! I have work to do!” He stood to walk to his office door.

We remained seated.

“You’re known to the local Police for domestic violence offences.”

“Jeez…I will admit that my first marriage was a little…arrh…how shall I say it…a little violent. We could go hammer and tong at one another, but it was my name that was recorded each time the local cops were called even if my face was covered in blood…and it was my name only that was recorded as part of the divorce proceedings…she ended up as the ‘golden girl’. Arrh, what’s the use, that was years ago. I am happily married to my second wife, and we still get on like a house on fire after what…seven years of marriage with two adorable kids…if you have had enough?” A question as he opened the door. He had been standing there gripping the doorknob during this outburst to show he was a good bloke after all.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

"That didn't go too badly…" I quipped, a smile to stir Angie…it succeeded.

"Whaaart!! I doubt he will be that charitable if we want to contact him again." She responded curtly.

"I don't know…who was going to benefit the most in Zed Cameron's disappearance and possible death?"

"Arrh…I guess…arrh… Verge Burram…are you now accusing him of killing his partner so that he has…you know…the firm to himself!"

"He has full control over the one-man business he now owns lock, stock, and barrel. A house in Birchgrove, the business address in the Balmain Shopping mall and a 'summer house' in the southern highlands worth a motza."

"You think he did? You know…do his mate in?" Angie asked incredulously.

"It's a thought…an avenue to investigate but no…I'm not convinced of his involvement. He stopped the relationship he had with Jennifer Crowe because he felt it was wrong though he never criticised his mate for continuing with the same arrangement with the added temptation of regular sex with the woman…even understanding and accepting that his mate had run off with the woman without a word said…all stated in a matter-of-fact manner…that is not the heart of a killer…"

"Or for that matter a Real Estate Agent!"

"Amen to that!"

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

"What do we know about the house that we are sure Jennifer Crowe's body is buried in?" I asked merely to get the ball rolling. We were sitting opposite one another brainstorming trying to get closer to her location as we thought we had nothing.

“Mmm…on the Drummoyne or the Balmain headland. Single storey. A covered veranda for the full length of the front of the house. A huge tree in the neighbouring property that partially shades the house in question. A lightweight carport off the side of the house that is not in keeping with the rest of the house. A driveway to the right as you look at the place from the street that leads up to the carport and beyond to a garage at the rear property line. It is a deep block…deeper than the normal sixty-metre-deep block. Be worth a fortune now that sub-division of the block would be permitted. The driveway is steep from the street before it flattens out at the front of the house. The house a little small. Built like many of its day on a small footprint. Four built-up veggie patches in the back yard that takes up the area from the back fence to the front of the garage so the vegie patches are something like six metres long by four metres in depth which means there must be a central ‘walkway’ to each plot…arrh…the distance between each plot is anyone’s guess…mmm…maybe a shed off the side of that garage…could be the shed is to the end of the garage…”

“You can’t see them from the front of the house, and I doubt the rear garage is noticeable from the street…” I corrected her. She nodded, silently agreeing with me.

“Yeah…the house to the rear of our property is on higher ground; the rear of the house built on a smooth exposed rock shelf as the underside of the house is noticeable…um…and open…anything else?” She had supplied most of the information that had a ring of truth about it…she’d been Googling or something!

“Um…no.” I confirmed. “Oh, one more thing. The street and the house are on the high side of the headland and the street. The front veranda offers views of the Harbour and Harbour Bridge. The house was briefly listed and sold about five to seven years ago, based on my estimate.”

“Okay…Google Streetscape…” Angie suggested. “A quicker way to drive those streets at the top of the headland facing east than actually driving those streets…I’ll do the Balmain Peninsular first before turning my attention to the Drummoyne headland…a couple of days work. Okay. Leave me alone will you?”

I did not have a clue what she was on about! I wheeled my chair around to her desk as she tapped away on her keyboard. The City CBD over-view came up then the Balmain Headland. Zeroing in she flipped the image from plan view to streetscape which gave a reasonably good view of each house frontage.

“On the high side of the street…and a large tree…” She mumbled away to herself as she drove slowly along the street. I shook my head and scooted back to my desk amazed at how coppers of yesteryear were ever successful in resolving a murder investigation.

Two days later a cry of success broke the silence between us.

“There we go!” She exclaimed successfully. “Oops…I’m a little scratchy in controlling the screen views.”

As I lent closer to the screen two views jumped about on her split screen before settling above the roofline of the house. I pointed a finger at the image. The veggie gardens were still prominent in the back yard but had grown to six. The garage and shed were as I had envisaged them, but the house was now a two-storey colonial structure that spread across the block leaving only a driveway that led up the right side of the house as you looked at it from the street. A very large Gum tree in the far left-hand front corner of the neighbouring property partially shaded our house in question.

“You are one clever lady, Angie. You are right. That is the house that we have been looking for. Good on you girl…sorry…young lady…”

“My name is Angelica or Angie to my friends and partner, thank you.” She looked condescendingly towards me, nodding her head. A slight smile or grimace…I was not too sure. “What now?” She asked wanting to cool the situation. She never argued with me and always agreed with my opinions.

“We go and look at the house and land to confirm our suspicions. If we are convinced of our find, we start the ball rolling to determine whether a body is buried in one of those plots…or not. Ange? We are on the right track.”

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

We were parked opposite the premises in question. Sydney was draped in low grey clouds. An occasional thunderclap heralded the rain to follow.

“Who-ever did the design work and detail on those extensions both up and out did a bloody good job. You cannot tell where the extensions begin, and the original house finished. It looks at home where it is and the views from the first-floor balcony would be world beating.” I crooned. “Betcha it doubled the value of the property with that extension…”

“At least!” Angie added. “Though that house behind it spoils it a bit. It needs a lot of love and money to bring it up to scratch. Betcha it’s a bit draughty with the brick piers somewhat three to four metres high and at least two metres apart with nothing between them…that side is exposed to the nor-east through the south-east wind quadrant…yeah…a bit draughty…yeah, spoils the look of our house in front of it a bit. It’s a pity you cannot force your neighbour to beautify their residence…that is what is needed, yeah?” She looked away then back again.

“Can you do that? You know, force your neighbour to upgrade his house? Beautify it with a coat of paint…or something? Nah…no way.” She answered her own question.

“C’mon, before it starts raining. Let’s take a squiz. Bring your umbrella with you.” I instructed as I opened the passenger door to climb out. The Unmarked was becoming a little low for me to alight comfortably from…it’s been getting worse as the years roll by. With a groan and a moan, I stood straightening my aching back slowly. As we made the middle of the street a thunderclap exploded directly above us. We both cowered. Angie squealed.

“I do not think we are gunna make that carport in the back yard. Head for the front veranda.” I instructed. Head bowed we made a dash for it as a chilly wind picked up. We scampered through the ajar front gate to bound up the four front steps onto the safety of the covered veranda as the heavens split open. We could hear the deluge progressing up the Harbour. The splash of large droplets of water close to hail.

“Bloody hell! You’d think we were in the tropics!” Angie began, interrupted by the front insect screen door squeaking open and an authoritative voice demanding why we were standing on his front veranda. There was nothing that we could sell him…buy from him or convert him into becoming a religious nutter! If we wanted an interview, we needed to consult with his manager…

“Arrh…yes…” I offered, turning to voice as the rain pelted down near splashing our shoes. I offered my ID Card.

“Murder Squad Senior Detective Joseph Lind and…” Turning to my much younger partner I introduced Detective Angie De Longo. She almost curtsied…I frowned wondering what she was doing!

“I watched you park your car on the other side of the street to make a beeline for here. I cannot do little else but sit and look out the window until I am allowed to fling these blasted crutches away. The way the rain followed up the Harbour was intriguing. That’s when I saw youse scampering across the street heading for here. What do you want of me? Oh! My name is Mark Goodall.”

“The League player?” Angie exclaimed excitedly. She recognised him as soon as he had appeared.

Surprisingly, we see very little of celebrities either of the Sports Arena or the Entertainment Business during our examinations of Cases. Consequently, we react like normal people meeting a ‘famous’ person for the first time.

"Once upon a time…" Goodall lamented. "This latest bout of injuries marks the end of my football career. Not me making the decision but the Team Doctor and my Coach. I will not bemoan its ending. I had enough of the daily grind by the start of this season…no, I am not sorry to call it quits…why have you landed on my front porch? Look, come through to the Kitchen where I can shout you a decent coffee and where it is warmer." He opened the door wide to invite us in.

After we had settled at the Kitchen Bench sitting on the latest trend of high stool, a mug of coffee in our hands, he sat awkwardly, one leg in a moon brace being supported on a scooter-like contraption, he gave us the once over and asked, "What do two Murder Squad Detectives want with me or my house?"

"Yes…we believe a body could be…might be buried in your veggie patch. We would like your permission to conduct a non-intrusive ground radar search of that area…when the weather clears…"

"Yeah, they reckon this has set in for at least a week…a body you reckon. Hah! No wonder my veggie patch is so productive! Sorry, my sick sense of humour is all…wait until the missus hears of why our vegie patch is the envy of the neighbourhood." He shook his head and tried to stifle a laugh. "Yeah, do what you are meant to do after this rain has passed over…"

I walked to the outside rear veranda to make the calls. The Ground Penetrating Radar Machine needs drier conditions than currently experienced and requires at least a two-week lead-in preparation period. I have scheduled this for three weeks from now. The Forensic Trace and Forensic Pathology Teams for the same time. If something suspicious is located by the machine, the Pathology mob will want to commence digging immediately.

I could feel my heart rate and adrenaline rise…we were close, I could feel it…now to wait patiently until something turns up…that is the hard part!

And what to do to fill in the time!?

That is the harder part!!

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

The habitual Monday morning Staff Meeting was continued by our new Boss 'Ronnie' Faye who we learnt quickly had a short fuse but usually overlooked the misdemeanour of one of

her subordinates the next time they had dealings with one another…it seemed she had forgotten about it…

Last week it had been my turn as the most senior Dee on the floor to lead out the meeting. This Monday it was the junior pair to head proceedings. D2 Caroline Clerk and her senior partner D3 Fergy Stephenson. They had just landed a Case. A body partially unearthed on a back road leading into the small town of Branxton. Nothing known at this stage except his name…Zed Cameron. His wallet was still with the remains.

“Say that again…” I sat up and was all ears. My heart skipping a beat.

“Zed Cameron…you know of him?” Fergy Stephenson replied.

“Arrh…Joseph Lind doing it again…trying to steal other team’s cases…easy as…” One of the stirrers from the floor interjected.

“Yes…no…I do not want additional cases that would involve me robbing them from my colleagues…we have enough on our plate as it is. He is central to our Missing Body Case. That of Missus Jennifer Crowe. It was thought at one stage that he and Crowe had run off together, but we now suspect that Cameron could have…could have been killed by Geof Crowe, Jennifer Crowe’s husband with the killer of Jennifer Crowe due out of prison for the crime this winter coming. The evidence that put him there all circumstantial with a heavy reliance on forensic trace material. How can you be sure your remains are those of Zed Cameron?” Asking the obvious.

“You certain of Geof Crowe’s involvement?” The Boss interrupted, turning to me.

“Not at this stage as there is insufficient evidence to arrest him but…”

“So, it’s a gut feeling on your part Joe?” The Boss stated forcefully.

“It would seem Zed Cameron and Jennifer Crowe were having a romantic interlude and as I stated before, there were hints the two were going to run off together. Enough reason for the hubbie to go after Zed Cameron I would have thought.” I countered.

“A good enough reason to suspect the hubbie I guess.” The Boss agreed quietly.

I lowered my head. Nodded.

“Go for the hubbie first, huh?” She continued appearing to enjoy the gambit.

I again nodded; my head still lowered in quiet acquiescence.

"Right!" The Boss seemed to jerk herself out of the ploy she was playing with me. "This body find of Zed Cameron? Fergy? Hand all you have gathered so far on the Case over to Joe here…it involves multiple homicides while the paramount reason for his input was to find Jennifer Crowe's body which it seems, he has found…both you Joe and Angie should be congratulated for locating the woman's remains…arrh…these other missing persons associated with the Case can be acted upon by you Joe and Angie De Longo as there appears to be definite links…okay?"

The Boss had just given us approval to continue with other missing persons involved or attached to the Jennifer Crowe Case. She is not so bad after all…at least she was fair and could get a quick understanding of what the situation was and who was involved…

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

Thank God for the GPS thingamajig as we would be in Broken Hill instead of fifty kays south of Branxton in the Hunter Valley. In small hobby farm country.

We crossed over a rickety, wooden, one-lane bridge that spanned a languid stream to be immediately stopped by a Uniform Officer. After identifying ourselves he directed us to the left when the main dirt road turned sharply right to climb up the side of the valley. We did not get that far…perhaps two…three hundred metres to the left before being stopped by a mishmash of official vehicles and local Council heavy trucks and Bossman cars.

After identifying everyone, we presented ourselves to the supervisor in front of all the Council Road Workers, introducing ourselves collectively.

"Yes, that is right. Part of the body was unearthed an hour about before knock-off time last night. Because the Foreman-in-charge could see a late night if he informed the Authorities then, he waited until first thing after cuppa-time this morning. You coppers and scientific fellows were quickly on scene. While I may not agree with the actions of my foreperson, I will not criticise him for his decisions…after all, the body has been here for around fifteen years, so the scientific people are saying. What's a couple of hours…" He held his arms akimbo looking for a pardon for his workers.

"What were your people doing around here in order to find the body?" Angie asked.

“Um…we are using this area…this layback to store road ballast. This Financial Year…or more likely the one after that to replace the existing wooden bridge with one more substantial. There has been a one hundred percent increase in traffic over this road over the past ten years and the bridge is suffering. The last floods she went under. We have done strengthening work but at close to one hundred years old, the bridge has reached its safety limits…”

I held my tongue. The failure to inform the correct authorities of a body find is liable to at least a hefty fine if not a prison sentence! Instead, I nodded and headed towards the Chief Forensic Science Officer on-site, Dee Dee Symonds.

“I was hauled out of bed this morning by the persistent ring of my mobile at an ungodly hour to travel all the way up here…three minutes from Boonsville! It’s Zed Cameron you want, so yer missus tells me…at least she is closer to home at Drummoyne Headland.” She shook her head and stamped her white rubber boots on the ground. “Joe, leave off! It is imperative that no additional bodies are discovered, as our Trace Teams and Pathology Units are currently operating at full capacity. We may have to ask for help from Brisbane if more bodies are turned up…expecting any more Joe?”

I shook my head and laughed.

“How has the remains been identified as those of the missing Zed Cameron?” Asking the obvious.

“A wallet…with over one thousand dollars inside. It sure wasn’t a robbery. This is a crime of passion, I reckon. With that type of cash in his wallet, the guy was heading out…pissing off to somewhere…”

“He was known for that…with Missus Jennifer Crowe in tow so goes the whispers…” Angie confided.

My mobile rang. It was my wife who was Lead Forensic Officer On-site at the Jennifer Crowe dig.

“Where are you?” No fuss or good morning though lunch time was not that far off and we were miles from any food dispenser! That made my stomach rumble even more.

“At Zed Cameron’s burial site. South of Branxton on the back road to Cessnock.” I replied deadpan.

“Yeah…Dee Dee told me they’d found his body…look…any chance you can get here sometime this afternoon?”

“Um…why? It will take us…I don’t know…two hours I guess…to go from here to your dig.”

“You are that far away…sorry. Any chance though?”

“Important huh?”

“I think so, yes. I think it is very important. What we have found…or one of my inquisitive Helpers have found is suspiciously looking like the weapon that killed Jennifer Crowe…one tap to her head with a hammer that has skin, hair and bone fragments still on the hammer head and a set of fingerprints…palmprints actually…and skin and blood trace in a splintered section of the hammer handle…we’ve sent it off for immediate attention…should have a preliminary report back by the end of the week…”

“So why do you want Ange and I down there in such a hurry?”

“I think it is a big find and that inquisitive little helper could do with a tap on the shoulder as a means of congrats…understand?”

I nodded. Yes, I understood. It is important to give dues where congrats are warranted. It could mean the difference between enthusiasm and a ‘who cares’ attitude.

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

It was mid-afternoon by the time Angie and I arrived at the house at Drummoyne Headland. We walked up the rear drive to find my wife taking a break enjoying a coffee.

“We could do with one of those and any sandwich left over from lunch. Neither of us has eaten or drunk anything since we’ve been at the Branxton site.”

“Can do my love. Can do.” She offered as she rummaged around in the ‘slide-out’ fridge/freezer in the rear of one of the Forensic Utes. She offered me a sardine and tomato sandwich. Angie took a chicken and mayonnaise. Steaming hot mugs of coffee offered to both of us…from where, I am still uncertain.

“Joe? This is Megan Wright, one of my Assistants who found the killer hammer…and who also makes a bloody good coffee.”

“Megan…you opened the entire case up and once DNA comparison tests are completed, we will know for sure who killed Jennifer Crowe and who buried her…we have money on it being Murray Bridge being the burial master which this will confirm. He has already confessed to burying the poor woman. And it strengthens the case against Perry Matthews as the circumstantial evidence against him was scratchy. Well done young lady…” I glanced across at Tellie who nodded her thanks for me not addressing the young lady as ‘girlie.’

The three of us leaned against Tellie’s Forensic Ute finishing off our sandwiches, taking small sips at the piping hot coffee. I jutted my mug towards the rear property.

“They got that scaffolding up quick.”

“Yeah…they got what they wanted delivered yesterday afternoon and stuck it up today. They had to get permission from Mark Goodall to place bracing lengths onto his property…they do not affect us at all…they asked.”

“What do they intend to do? You know, what work is to be undertaken?”

“According to the scaffolders they’re going to infill that huge area under the house making another level with additional accommodation in the roof space with those fancy windows with the living quarters upstairs for the better view, having a large balcony on this lower level and the one above cantilevered out over nothing…it would have to come close to the boundary line. The Burram Real Estate Agency once owned the house…the same Firm that used to own this house…both, I bet sold for squillions. That one up there used to be a dosh house…a different meaning today. Used to be Uni students…mainly Sydney Uni students who used to call the joint home…they tell me the new owners are spending a huge sum of money doing the joint up…should make the joint look a squillion-dollars and a far better view from there than what it is like at this place…”

“Sydney University students you reckon. Where did you learn that?” A spark flew across my synapses when the link with the Sydney University students was mentioned. The majority listed as POI’s on our Excel Spreadsheet were Sydney Uni students who were regular clientele of our ‘friendly’ Jennifer Crowe …

“From Mark Goodall.” Tellie jerked her head towards our lovely colonial restoration. “It was still a dosh house…that’s what he called it…when he and his missus first purchased this joint.”

I nodded, my head still abuzz with the connection between Uni students and the house perched above us on a huge smooth rock shelf.

CHAPTER FORTY

We switched from both burial sites Branxton and Drummoyne every day clocking up the miles.

Out of the blue I opened the conversation as we headed towards the Branxton 'dig' with Angie who disliked having deep conversations while she was driving.

"On your Excel Spreadsheet, was there any indication that any of our young chaps back fourteen years ago lived in that house above the Goodall place?"

"Mmm…" There was silence for a bit. "You can bring up that information onto your iPad easy as."

Yeah, perhaps for you, but me! She must have felt my discomfort and inability to achieve that action, so she led me through it step by step…rather simple really!

"Four…no five at times used that to kip and to use as their postal address. Five out of the twenty names of young guys…we have four persons still noted as missing although I reckon the remains at Branxton are those of Zed Cameron…his wallet within the burial site confirms that until we have further DNA familial proof."

"Killed by Geof Crowe, Jennifer Crowe's husband though this is…"

"A gut feeling." I filled in the gaps for her much as Marge Hendricks and I had done thirty-odd years ago…we were becoming a team. I smiled to myself, satisfaction, and laughter a mixture on my face.

The Branxton 'dig' had fully exposed the remains, and they had commenced placing the bones out onto the preparatory table to photograph and label each bone before tumbling them into a body bag to transport to the Morgue for autopsy detail.

"We've recovered an Athletic Singlet…one made from synthetic material that does not deteriorate as fast as wool or cotton…" She showed me several photographs on her iPad of the find. "It has a reputation of trapping skin and sweat modules between the fibres. We have sent it off as an urgent listing to the Laboratory…" Dee Dee smiled apologetically. "We have three Laboratory Assistants coming down from Brisbane and two up from Melbourne this weekend to help. Our Laboratory is empty pretty much as we considered the importance was here on the ground, so we've got almost all hands on these digs…what with the third body discovered, that has really stretched us to over our limits…you know, we have a normal load

each week but with these…and the Forensic Lab will be over-stretched once all these specimens for examination are received…"

"Third body!?" I looked at her surprised…maybe it was a slip of the tongue or…

"Yeah…early this morning. Workers were digging out the dirt with one of those small Diggers with a 'double cup' on the front of it. Needed to use that equipment because of the head height. Yeah, they were digging out the dirt from under the house positioned above the Goodall's place…you know, where the scaffolding is…when they uncovered a torso…not buried that deep…a male…late teens to mid-twenties…the scalp rendered multiple fractures possibly from a hammer…what? Hasn't Tellie informed you yet?" Dee Dee was dismayed that her best friend had not yet advised the Lead Detective of the find.

"Arrh…no!" I replied a little irate. I ran my fingers through my thinning grey hair as a sign of my frustration. My mobile began its infuriating buzz telling me I had an incoming call. "That'll be Tellie wanting to apologise." I informed Dee Dee sardonically.

"I doubt it!" Dee Dee stated ironically as she walked away leaving me to answer Tellie's call.

"You've found another cadaver…or a pile of bones?" I stated sarcastically as my opening gambit.

"No need for that tone and yes, human remains that we guess are around fifteen years old…identification will have to be a slow familial trace DNA comparison examination I'm afraid."

"Which I'm sure you're very capable of carrying out…" Again, my tone one of sarcasm.

"What's got up your nose, old man?" She returned the sarcasm. She would never confess to ignoring proper procedures. "I have emailed photographs…a couple of the body and a few of a silver box chain and a heavy silver pendant found under the house close to the body dig. On the reverse side is engraved:

PIM
Love from
SIS.

On the face side is engraved PIM's Gemini sign."

"Who is SIS…and for that matter who is PIM?" My sarcasm cooling as information I was given appeared important and I was not picking up on it!

“PIM? Called that by his family for most of his life. Ditto his Uni colleagues. Three guesses.”

I did not have a clue and said as much. Becoming irate at this too and fro nonsense!

“You are slowing down old man. PIM. Perry Isaac Matthews…and SIS? His sister Pamela Matthews whom PIM always called SIS. This golden chalice found metres from the body, which only confirms the man was under the house, I guess. The chain and pendant confirmed as belonging to Matthews by his sister. We sent photographs of the jewellery for her to identify.”

“How’d you manage to trace her out?” Still annoyed at her for carrying out my job.

“She was a character witness for her brother in PIM’s homicide trial back then. We approached the Defence Team for her address only. They agreed saying it was very unorthodox though they would oblige! She resides in Ashfield and is the General Buyer for one of the large Supermarkets. She was angry as she had given PIM that pendant and chain in two thousand and nine for his birthday. Less than six months later he had lost it…we are yet to identify the remains by DNA comparison study.”

By the tone of her voice and her want to advise me of everything she had achieved, she was none the wiser in breaking protocol...she was proud in what she had accomplished!

“In proximity…that is where the jewellery was found. The Defence will have a field day with that producing a thousand reasons why PIM was under that house…none of them to do with the homicide of the discovered remains…” I calculated trying to burst her balloon.

“That’s for you to sort out as the ace Detective…go to it Ralph!” She hung up before I could chastise her for overstepping her area of responsibility and expertise. I knew the slight unpleasantness would have evaporated by the time I arrived home for dinner…or it better had otherwise I would be sleeping in the spare bed…or out in the caravan!

CHAPTER FORTY-ONE

Her Office wasn’t really an office just the cut-off end of a corridor. A pile of paper seemed to take up every available space, so much so that her desk had been pushed to the rear wall and her line of sight was a remaining wall space filled with “foolscap and A4 paper” of importance to someone. It looked like a ‘hurricane left-over’ to me.

She turned her back on her desk to speak with us. I was sitting out in the corridor.

"You were a Character Witness in your brother's trial some twelve years ago. Did the Defence team call you up for that?" I asked after pleasantries were exhausted.

"Arrh…yes…yes, I am sure. I was not cross-examined by the Prosecution Team which surprised me. If they had I would have had to describe PIM's atrocious jealousy streak which would have explained why he had killed that woman…"

"Missus Jennifer Crowe…" Angie offered.

"Yeah…though I had forgotten her name. Shameful, eh? He would not have liked another guy getting more attention from the woman than him…his attitude would be *'if I can't have her, then no-one can'* and *'if I can't have her than there is no way you're having her.'* I'm sure that is what would have motivated his actions in killing that poor woman for which he has paid the price. I am not sure he killed and buried that guy under that house where that scientific lady said it was placed…maybe PIM did it…I'm not sure. Either way, that is not my brother." There was silence as she looked up at the ceiling. She coughed before continuing. "As an example of his wide jealousy streak, I think I could have been ten…PIM two years my junior. He got a puppy from Mum and Dad for his birthday. The puppy came to me first. Would not have a thing to do with him. PIM hit the roof, taking almighty kicks at the poor thing which earned him a hiding from Dad. It was no-more than a couple of months later that Dad found the poor puppy out in the backyard lying on its side. Blood frothing from its mouth. Dad shot the poor pup. Buried it in the backyard. We all knew what had happened, but no-one spoke a word about it…ever. That never came out in the Trial…it should have…"

"It wouldn't have made any difference to the result…he was as guilty as all hell…" I offered the woman. She nodded and murmured 'yeah' in reply.

"Yes…we have further proof of him being involved in the Crowe homicide…irrefutable proof that denies his constant cry of innocence." I added.

I showed her the photographs of the box necklace and pendant.

"I said to that woman who rang me and emailed the same photos across to my private mobile phone that that was the present I gave PIM for his twentieth birthday in twenty-oh-nine…and he'd lost the bloody thing inside six months of receiving it which is just like him! He could not care less!"

"When is his birthday?"

"June three…"

I nodded. I did not know what that had to do with the price of cow manure in Gerringong but what the hell!

We bade farewell to the frazzled woman not too sure what we had learnt and whether it would help us in the future. We suspected Perry Matthews may have killed the person whose body had just been found under the house, and I still had that gut feeling that Geof Crowe was the guilty party in disposing of the body of Zed Cameron out Branxton way…but we were still awaiting forensic proof of identity of the two lots of remains and their executioners. We could not act any further until we had more concrete proof…and the way the Science Lab was working now, it could be several weeks before we have irrefutable proof of the crimes, and the persons involved.

Angie and I sat in our Unmarked not saying a word, lost in our own thoughts until Angie spoke.

"Seems to me we are heading in the same direction as the first homicide…reliant on circumstantial evidence and nothing more for Perry Matthews' guilt."

"Mmm…you could be right. I'm darned sure we will never get a confession out of the man. Let's be patient as there is a mountain of work that Forensic Trace must get through before we give up…patience. dear girl. Patience."

CHAPTER FORTY-TWO

"What are we doing here, Joe?" Angie asked a little peeved at being back at this remote locale where the Forensic Trace and Forensic Pathologist had long cleared the area. You would not have known that a body had once been buried there.

"In its own tranquil way, this is a nice place to be buried." I proffered lyrically. "It will be a pity when they do away with that old historical bridge…can they do that? Destroy an historical bridge…"

Angie ignored me.

The local Council or Roadworks people had tipped further truckloads of road base and other materials ready for the reconstruction of the rickety, century-old single lane bridge…well, if they are allowed to do such a thing.

“There was a detail listed somewhere in the Trial Transcript…I’m sure that is driving me crazy…something that links someone of interest with a hobby that requires an athletic singlet…ring any bells with you?” I asked suddenly, completely bamboozling Angie. She was still thinking of the removal of an historical bridge with a wider, higher version. It took her some moments to reply. Conversing as she shook her head.

“Let me bring up the Trial Transcript on my iPad…isolate ‘*athletic past times’* and see what comes up.” She danced across the miniature keyboard as she hummed out of tune which grated on me. I slid the window down to listen to a myriad bird calls most of which were new to me. Each having its own melodious song book…never sang out of tune.

“*Athletic past time* mentioned nine times during trial…six linked to Geof Crowe…surprise, surprise. Let’s see if he has a Face Book Page which we can examine going back twenty years.” Again, the out of tune humming. I guess it has always been a habit of hers, but I’d never noticed it before. The two of us in the Unmarked made the grating noise more noticeable.

“Yep…a ribbon several times in High School for Cross Country running competitions. He went a little quiet during his university days…”

“Too busy fishing with his three mates.” I interrupted.

“…but he has entered every Sydney Marathon and several other provincial marathons and half-marathons since those days…no ribbons or medals but at least he finished respectfully in the top twenty every time…”

“I think we should have a word with the man to see what comes of it. Where does he work? Do we have it listed?”

Angie again danced across the miniature keyboard of her iPad. It did not take her long to reply.

“Parramatta…the CBA Bank…Second Assistant to the Manager of the International Monetary Fund whatever that entails.”

“Parramatta…tomorrow morning, eh?”

Angie leant forward to start the engine.

“No Ange…let’s stay here for a bit longer. It is such a beautiful, calm, and serene place…let us sit and appreciate it for a bit.”

“Closer to God, eh?” Angie replied sarcastically knowing of my atheist beliefs.

“No…closer to Mother Nature for God is missing having never been around here…there were four missing persons on that Excel Broadsheet you constructed…who were they again?”

Angie shook her head, once again flummoxed by my sudden change of subject. She slumped back in her seat, picked up her iPad and once again began to dance across the keyboard.

“Um…Zed Cameron, Vlad Sumner, Allan Price, and Andy Seppi. I will take a bet that at least one of them is alive and living interstate. Got the fuck outa here when it was obvious his life was in danger…”

“Only one?”

“That would statistically be about right.” She shot back sure of her assessment.

“We have recovered Jennifer Crowe’s remains which should indicate that Zed Cameron is dead also…we have three left; one of which you say is statistically still alive. Wasn’t it suggested that Vlad Sumner also had sex with Missus Crowe but on an irregular basis…maybe only once or twice…but that would get him killed for sure…either by our Mister Crowe or Perry Matthews as PIM would have been his competitor so the psycho would have thought…that leaves both Allan Price and Andy Seppi with one of them still alive.”

“Yeah…I’ll go along with that…”

“Go back through the Centrelink records. Fourteen/fifteen years ago both had either just finished their Degrees at Uni and were pulling Centrelink payments…or they had walked straight into a job.”

Again, the out of tune humming. I bet she did not even know she was humming and in such a terrible tone. This time it took her a while to search through ‘The Cloud’ and several other sites I knew little of. I hopped from the Unmarked to lean against the front mudguard. It was times like these that I longed for that cigarette again. Instead, I allowed my mind to go blank. I leant back into the open front passenger door to inform Angie of my brain wave.

“Angie? Both Price and Seppi are still alive…”

“Yes…Price is working for an Architectural Firm in Auckland in New Zealand while Seppi works for Snowy Two and resides in Cooma. He is a Hydraulic Engineer. How did you know they were still alive?”

“Deduction, dear girl. Deduction. That means that the body buried under the house is Vlad Sumner and the one buried out here is Zed Cameron. Forensics will be able to confirm either way shortly. They have had a full complement plus those short-term relief staff from Brisbane and Melbourne helping from last Monday.” I straightened and moaned my way back onto the front passenger seat of our Unmarked. “Come on, let us go sit down in a Chinese Restaurant and enjoy a decent lunch as an extended lunch hour. We haven’t had one for yonks…then we can go home with full stomachs for once. Tomorrow morning we’ll pay Geof Crowe a visit and if things go according to Hoyle, we’ll spend the rest of the week on paperwork charging the bloke with either one of those body dumps…or both! Next week we’ll arrest and charge Murray Bridge with multiple offences. All being well, the Court will go kindly on the man who has suffered a guilty conscious for fourteen years…don’t you think?”

“You think!?” Angie asked as she turned the motor over. “A Chinese Restaurant out this way! Do you know of one?”

“Arrh…Maitland, Kurri Kurri, or Cessnock. Take your pick. Check out the best one using that wonderfully clever device that you can navigate through so easily before you take off!”

CHAPTER FORTY-THREE

I had the feeling we were going down into the depths instead of climbing the heights of the tall building. One of the tallest in the Parramatta CBD now. It will soon be surpassed by several developments under construction, but it was uncertain if they had reached our current level underground.

We were ushered into a large office space that had large computer screens on three walls. All blinking, all scrolling. Not one static!

Geof Crowe stood as we entered, shaking our hands and offering us two visitors chairs facing his desk. He nodded at the two Security Guards who had accompanied us down into the depths. We glanced around at the myriad computer screens, confusion absolute.

“Yeah…” Crowe tittered. “No need to worry unless all these and all those out on the general floor go blank…then we have just been nuked…” He laughed at his own joke, cutting off the chortle when he saw we weren’t enjoying his humour. His humour falling flat on both Angie and me. He coughed. “Two Homicide Detectives. What do you want with me?”

“Your wife…” I began.

“Lucy?”

“No…your first wife Jennifer…”

“Ooh! That’s ancient history…the chap responsible should be out of jail by now though the bastard doesn’t deserve to be…”

“Middle of this winter coming…you were once an Orienteering and Marathon runner…” Angie asked, wanting to settle the man. I would let here lead…

“Yeah…lonely early morning runs summer and winter…those days of competing are long gone though I still put in the metres each week just to keep fit…keep the old heart beating.” He smiled thinking of earlier times when he was competitive.

“C’mon Mister Crowe, you’re not that old. It was not that long ago you were a university student with a young wife. You’ve sure jumped up the corporate ladder.” Angie observed as she looked around. There would be at least two dozen staff out on the General Office area. “What exactly do you do here?” Ange asked to settle the bloke. At the mention of his first wife, he had visibly stiffened.

He relaxed. Smiled though it looked a little forced.

“All Banks worldwide have a similar Section as this. We move money around trying to snag the best interest rates for the money…your money that is, as we can. The profits become the Bank’s after we have paid you interest on your savings and shares to our loyal shareholders. Simple as…”

I nodded. I had not imagined the scale of the operation that allowed me my interest on my money and the shareholders’ annual payment.

“You and Jennifer would have had the world at your feet what with the Bank putting you through university and all…and they were future-planning this job for you.” Angie concluded, her head to one side.

“Mmm…I had to fight my way over several bodies but yes, me and Lucy are leading very comfortable lives now…” Crowe let out a weary sigh. “Um…Jens…she was not one for investing years into the future. She was more a *‘now’* type of woman.” He fidgeted, moving his feet about under his large desk. “She was easily bored…you know, I couldn’t satisfy her, and I had trouble keeping up with her. She could be easily persuaded by any smooth-tongued, snake-oil charmer like Zed Cameron who promised her the world right away. Plans that involved exotic places and wonderful scenery and climate…she would never think all these

promises were nothing but bullshit…she loved the idea of tropical paradises being easy money destinations…"

He turned away as he began to sob, large sobs that wracked his body. Staff sitting close to the Office must have heard as they looked up, concern on their faces. As he rose, he pulled a large handkerchief from his pocket to blow his nose. Before settling back again, he closed his office door that only added further concern from those sitting nearby.

"We have found Zed Cameron's remains out Branxton way on a formed layback that is a gravel dump for the local Council. Your synthetic yarn athletic singlet was found with the body. Forensic tests show your skin filaments and dried sweat beads all over it…have you anything to say about those facts?" I asked. Leading a little bit as we were yet to receive the forensic trace report as fact. Angie frowned at me as we yet had not received any such information from Forensics. I was pushing the truth to see where it would lead.

The man looked over at me through wet eyes. Nodded then sighed deeply. He had decided on an action that would turn his world upside down.

"The tragedy of it all was that Jens was killed a couple of days before I did away with Cameron. He was an AO still trying to adroitly worm his way out of certain death. I stabbed him …jeez…the more I stabbed the more I wanted to increase the stab wounds…there was blood all over the place…I was angry…no enraged at the bastard."

"Where was this?" I asked softly. Neither Angie nor I realised that I had taken over proceedings.

"On the banks of that stream. At first, I was just going to let him drop into the water but then realised his body would be easily spotted by anyone driving past. I had placed a shovel and pick in the boot of my car, so a burial was the next best thing. At first, I was going to bury him on the bank of the stream until…yeah…well…you look around and it is obvious there are regular floods that would have exposed the body. I was not that keen on having to carry the bastard too far so a spot at the rear of the layback was good enough…it was a bloody hot day with the valley trapping in the hot air…I can't remember exactly, but I guess I took off my singlet to wipe myself down. Thinking about it, a quick dip in the stream would have been better. Hah!" He shook his head now bowed almost to his desktop.

"How were you aware of this region?"

"Orienteering competitions often used that back road…it was out of the way and seldomly travelled."

“Let me get this clear…you are confessing to the stabbing homicide of Zed Cameron on or about January thirtieth two thousand and ten and disposing of the body in a short layback off the back road leading to Branxton in front of myself Senior Detective Joseph Lind and my junior partner Detective Angelica De Longo on the sixth of June twenty twenty-five at nine-oh- thirty AM in the office of the confessor. Is that about right?”

He nodded and began to sob again.

“Would you please stand and turn around so that we can handcuff you. We will take you to our Parramatta Headquarters building where you will be formally charged on suspicion of having stabbed Zed Cameron to death and disposing of his body. You can request Bail which we will not object to. If you meet Bail requirements you could be back behind this desk within a day or two. Do you understand these conditions?”

“I need you to let me walk unattended from this building…I will not object in any way.”

“I’m sorry sir, it is procedure that we handcuff you.”

He walked from his office as one would walk to the gallows. He had burdened himself with this guilt for close on fifteen years and like Murray Bridge, his entire being wished it to be over.

We spent two weeks constructing the paperwork to a satisfactory standard that the Boss would countersign. Luckily, we received a Preliminary Report on the grave of one Zed Cameron and all the forensic trace extracted from the area. The synthetic athletic singlet held skin molecules and dried sweat globules that with DNA comparison testing proved to be Geof Crowe’s.

Geof Crowe disappeared until the Preliminary Hearing then the Trial time in Court. When I interviewed him prior to the Preliminary Hearing, a mere formality under the circumstances, he was a broken man having lost a great deal of weight and muscle mass…he’d aged dramatically. I was concerned for his personal safety thinking he was a suicide risk…

CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR

We beeped up to Twelve-oh-two to converse with Murray Bridge.

“Hello. Who is there?” A woman’s voice enquired.

I placed my ID Card near the small lens.

“I am Senior Detective Joseph Lind of the Murder Squad with my partner Detective Angie De Longo. We’re looking for Murray Bridge. This is his Apartment.”

“I’m sorry I don’t know who you are talking about. My husband and I moved in two…no three weeks ago…”

“You pay rent to Murray Bridge…” I offered, getting a little nervous. I was hoping our man had not done another runner though it was in his blood and his character.

“No…the Company both my husband and I work for pay the rent. It’s part of our employment agreement. I haven’t a clue who the Company passes the money onto.”

“What is the name of that Company?” I asked, my ears pricking up.

“I think I’ve said enough. If you wish to obtain further information, I suggest you contact the HQ of Southern Gas and Oil Exploration in Pitt Street in the city. If that does not satisfy you then I am afraid I can’t help you any further…thank you.” She hung up.

I dug my hands deep into my pockets as we headed back towards our Unmarked.

“Shit! Looks like our bird may have flown the coup again. I doubt we’ll ever see him again though we’ll put out an ‘All Points’ for his immediate arrest. Wanted on suspicion of a homicide committed in two thousand and ten…bugger!

CHAPTER FORTY-FIVE

It was a mid-winter morning. One where both of us should still have been in bed! Instead, we were parked near the rear exit gate of Long Bay Penitentiary. Nestled in behind the large Bus Shelter where most crims having finished their sentences waited uncomplainingly for that bus to freedom. The nose of our Unmarked sticking out so we had a clear view of the rear exit gate where all Crims exit at the completion of their prison term.

We waited patiently for our ‘free man’ to emerge through that gate.

The cold sou-south-westerly was reducing the temperature to single digits, and I was not looking forward to alighting from the warm cocoon of our Unmarked when the man emerged from his twelve year incarceration.

“It does not look like he’s in a hurry to leave the place.” Angie gibed.

“Mmm…his bloody cell for the past umpteen years would seem warmer than out here…yeah…no…the gate is opening. Let’s go.” I ordered as I opened the car door, pulling my coat collar up and tightening the scarf around my neck. My Akubra that I rarely wore pulled down almost to my ears.

The man took two huge steps over and past the threshold of the security gate, dropped his meagre possessions of one medium sized cardboard box and a bulging, heavy-duty black plastic bag at his feet to fling his arms into the crispy, morning air…he was at last a free man!

He next turned his attention to the ‘Gate Guard,’ a huge man who made the other man look a darn sight smaller. Whether he promised a bear hug or the promise was telegraphed or choreographed, serious muttered words ended such action to be replaced by an energetic, vigorous handshake more so from our recently released cell-rat…the free man was not going to get away without some sort of action with the prison fraternity!

The guard ended the interaction with the former intern but a quick, affectionate slap on the cheek by the former cell-rat meant he had come out on top according to his opinion. The recently released man laughed then turned to retrieve his possessions to head for the bus shelter.

We beat him to the solidly built, weather and wind-proof shelter.

As he sat with a loud sigh placing those measly possessions he had between his feet, he exclaimed to no-one in particular, “Tis wonderful weather for it…”

“Depends on what ‘it’ is.” I replied deadpan.

He looked over at me for the first time…he then bent to glance at Angie. Doing a double take to concentrate on me. It was then that he noticed a ring of Uniformed Officers around the bus shelter.

“Coppers!! Christ, what have you got me for now?”

“Perry Matthews?” I stated softly. “Could you please stand and turn around…”

“You fucking dogs. What’re yer stitchen’ me up for now!?” Shouted out though there was a tinge of fear in it. He obeyed the order to stand mumbling something about the honesty, integrity and fair play that was missing from all coppers.

I gripped his shoulder as Angie did the honours.

“Perry Matthews? We are arresting you on suspicion of having killed Vlad Sumner on or around twenty-sixth January Twenty-ten and disposing of his body under the house at Number sixteen, Top Circuit fifteen/sixteen years ago. We also have sufficient evidence to confirm that you also killed Jennifer Crowe leaving her body unattended without notifying relevant authorities. You also refused to inform the relevant authorities of the death of Zac Cameron who was murdered then buried by Mister Geof Crowe. It is also noted that the Court, and in particular the Judiciary are not pleased with any fabrication of untruths being stated before the Parole Board at any time during a Panel Hearing. Such an offence is subject to a prison term…do you understand me?”

The man nodded, muttered his concurrence, his head down making him look as though he had forfeited any further life on the outside. That was the extent of his freedom…a walk to the bus stop where all released crims sat waiting for that ride to freedom. I think he realised he would probably die in prison.

“Anything you wish to share with us…” Angie concluded as she began to walk the man towards our Unmarked.

“I haven’t a bloody clue what you’re on about…I’m innocent, hear me? Innocent. Yer got nuttin’ on me…I’m innocent!!!”

Pcb

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